

# BLOOD, WATER & VIOLENT WIND

## A PLAYER'S PRIMER



*Resistance in the Shackles — liberty, and the reckoning that follows.*

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*A pirate campaign in the Pathfinder Shackles, run on the Resistance engine of Heart: the City Beneath. This primer is everything a player needs to roll up a pirate and understand a roll. The full rules live in the System Reference; the doom lives in the dice.*

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## CONTENTS

- |                     |                              |
|---------------------|------------------------------|
| 1. The Pitch        | 6. Callings — Why You Sail   |
| 2. The World        | 7. Classes — What You Can Do |
| 3. How to Play      | 8. Ancestries — Who You Are  |
| 4. The Five Tracks  | 9. Make Your Pirate          |
| 5. Skills & Domains | 10. Quick Reference          |

# THE PITCH

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## BLOOD, WATER & VIOLENT WIND

*A pirate campaign in the Shackles, using the Resistance system.*

You are not heroes; the sea does not care for heroes. You are pirates.

This campaign uses a homebrew system built on the foundation of *Heart: The City Beneath's* Resistance engine, with its nautical elements drawn from *Wildsea*. It is not a traditional toybox RPG the way D&D is. It is a game designed to tell a specific kind of story arc: the story of what piracy costs, and whether you believe that price is worth it.

You will have liberty. You will have light-hearted, spectacular, disreputable fun — the boarding actions, the impossible escapes, the nights in port that become legends. That part is real, and the system is built to let you enjoy it without apology.

And then there is the reckoning. The good times are real, and so is what comes after. Luck runs out. The sea keeps its own ledger. The most honest endings available in the Shackles are rarely the quiet ones — and your character will get to choose what theirs is worth.

The rest of this reference tells you how all of that works: the world you sail, the dice you roll, the harm you carry, the obsession that keeps you out here, and the hard-won expertise that has kept you alive so far.

# THE WORLD

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## THE SHACKLES

The Shackles is an archipelago of hundreds of islands stretching along the western coast of Garund, a large tropical continent reminiscent of Africa. It lies touching the south of the Eye of Abendego, an immortal hurricane that has not stopped spinning in over a thousand years. Nobody made it. Nobody can stop it. The northern Shackles are its permanent shadow.

The region exists in permanent opposition to civilised power. To the north, Cheliox is the dominant naval force of the Inner Sea — disciplined, aggressive, convinced of its own righteousness and the power of its devil gods. To the south, colonies support trade routes for far-flung empires in Tian Xia and eastern Garund. The Shackles exists, in large part, to rob both — along with everyone else they can find — and to drink well afterwards.

## THE FREE CAPTAINS & THE PIRATE COUNCIL

The Shackles has no state. What it has instead is the Free Captains: independent pirate lords who rule from their ships and their islands through reputation, violence, and the fragile web of obligation known as the Pirate Code. The most powerful of these captains sit on the Pirate Council, which meets in Port Peril, the largest city in the Shackles. The Council does not govern so much as manage conflict. It sets prizes, arbitrates disputes, and occasionally decides to make someone's life very short.

Port Peril is the heart of the Shackles — a teeming, dangerous, magnificent city built into a natural harbour, where every vice is available and every transaction has an

angle. It is where careers are made and ended, where the Pirate Code is law, and where the smell of salt and smoke never fully leaves the air.

## THE EYE OF ABENDEGO

The Eye is the defining feature of the Shackles. When it arrived a thousand years ago it destroyed the nation of Lirgen, the kingdom of Yamasa, and the empire of Ghol-Gan — and it has not relented since. It is supernaturally powerful; no natural storm sustains itself for a millennium. Scholars of the event believe it is either a manifestation of divine wrath — perhaps the death of a god — or the consequence of a ritual that went catastrophically wrong. Either way, it is not going anywhere.

The Eye shapes Shackles weather, Shackles culture, and Shackles theology. Besmara, the Pirate Queen — goddess of strife, sea monsters, and plunder — is worshipped here more fervently than anywhere else in the world. She does not promise safety. She promises that if you are strong enough, fast enough, and sufficiently disrespectful of consequences, you might deserve what you take.

## THE ISLANDS & THE DEEP

The Shackles' islands range from thriving pirate ports to uninhabitable jungle ecosystems to ruins that predate human civilisation. The cyclops empire of Ghol-Gan built its monuments across the entire archipelago before vanishing. Their ruins dot the landscape above water and below, still full of traps, guardians, and things that have been waiting in the dark for a long time. Older things still lurk in the deepest trenches and beneath certain islands that have never been properly settled, for reasons that become obvious quickly.

The sea itself is alive with magic: currents that seem to make navigational decisions; creatures of impossible size; ghost-lights that lead sailors to beautiful deaths; sea

witches who trade in storm-debts and claim the ocean as their territory; liches and dragons hiding deep in the jungle from adventurers seeking glory.

This is not a safe sea. But it is a magnificent one.

## THE CREW

The crew is everything. Not an abstraction, not a resource, not a means to an end — people, specific people, whose names you know and whose faces you could draw from memory in the dark. Pirates talk about freedom like it is a solo act. The best of them know better: the only real freedom most ever feel is the kind they share.

Whatever your character's private obsession, the ship and the hands aboard her are the ground you stand on — and, in this game, the thing the sea will most reliably use to hurt you.

# HOW TO PLAY

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This game runs on the Resistance engine from *Heart: The City Beneath*. Play is a conversation: the GM describes the world, you say what your character does, and dice are rolled only when an action has real stakes and an uncertain outcome. Everything below is the machinery beneath that conversation.

## THE CORE ROLL

When your character attempts something with potential consequences, you roll a pool of ten-sided dice (D10) and **keep the single highest** — you never add dice together. You always roll at least one die. Add another for a relevant **skill**, another for a relevant **domain**, and one more for a **mastery** die if a knack applies (to a maximum of four dice). More dice means a better chance of a high result.

| HIGHEST DIE | RESULT                                                                                                               |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 10          | <b>Critical success.</b> You get what you wanted, and something extra goes right. Step up your outgoing stress dice. |
| 8–9         | <b>Success.</b> You get what you wanted. No stress.                                                                  |
| 6–7         | <b>Success at a cost.</b> You get what you wanted, but you take stress or face a complication.                       |
| 2–5         | <b>Failure.</b> It goes wrong. You take stress; the GM describes what happens.                                       |
| 1           | <b>Critical failure.</b> It goes badly wrong. Take double stress.                                                    |

## DIFFICULTY

Most actions are **Standard** — roll your pool, keep the highest. When circumstances are against you, the action is harder:

- ◆ **Risky** — remove the highest die from your pool before reading the result.
- ◆ **Dangerous** — remove the two highest dice.

Good or excellent equipment, a clever plan, or the right preparation can step a Dangerous action down to Risky, or a Risky action down to Standard.

## STRESS & FALLOUT

Stress is the Resistance system's currency of consequence. It is not a hit-point bar. It is the accumulation of harm — physical, supernatural, social, fated, material — that erodes a person until something finally breaks.

When you fail or partially succeed, you **mark stress** to a track. The GM chooses the track based on what is happening in the fiction, not the skill you used, and sets the **stress dice** by severity:

| DICE | SEVERITY            |
|------|---------------------|
| D4   | Minor trouble       |
| D6   | Serious             |
| D8   | Genuinely dangerous |
| D10  | Catastrophic        |

**Protection** — from class abilities, circumstances, or the **Block** tag — reduces the number rolled before it is marked.

Each character has **five stress tracks**: Blood, Tide, Reputation, Luck, and Gold (see Part Four). The moment you mark stress, the GM rolls a **D12** and compares it to your **total** stress across all tracks:

| D12 VS. TOTAL STRESS                   | OUTCOME                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Higher than your total                 | No fallout. Stress accumulates.                                                                   |
| Equal or lower, and the D12 shows 1–6  | <b>Minor fallout.</b> Clear all stress in the marked track.                                       |
| Equal or lower, and the D12 shows 7–12 | <b>Major fallout.</b> Clear all stress from <b>all</b> tracks. Something has permanently changed. |

Fallout is the point of the system. It ranges from a passing inconvenience to a permanent change that reshapes who your character is. Sometimes it fires



immediately; sometimes it lingers for sessions. The fuller your tracks, the likelier the next mark tips you over — so recklessness is rewarded right up until the bill arrives.

Ships carry their own **Hull** track — structural damage, crew morale, the ability to keep sailing — separate from personal stress. When the Hull breaks, everyone aboard has a very bad day. The Hull rules live in the wider system documents (*Hull & the Ship*).

## CLEARING STRESS

Each track clears differently, and that is deliberate — see each track's entry in Part Four for the specifics. In short: **Blood** clears with rest, food, and a surgeon; **Gold** clears with plunder and good trades; **Reputation** clears with public, witnessed deeds (and through bonds and haunts); **Tide** resists clearing and usually needs ritual or arc-length story work; and **Luck** cannot be cleared by rest, coin, or carousing at all — it clears only when its fallout finally fires. Luck is the track that does not forgive. It is the mechanical promise at the centre of this game.

**Three ways to recover.** When a track *can* be cleared, it happens one of three ways: a **Tend roll** with the right gear (Part Nine) patches Blood, Gold, or the ship's Hull; a **haunt or a bond** in a friendly port (Part Eleven) buys back almost anything — including the stubborn Tide and Luck that nothing you can carry will touch; and ordinary **rest, plunder, and witnessed deeds** clear Blood, Gold, and Reputation over time. If you ever can't find "how do I heal this?", it is in one of those three.

## COMBAT AT CHARACTER SCALE

A fight runs on the same loop as everything else — there is no separate combat minigame. You say what you do; you roll when it's uncertain and costly; the consequence lands. A few things worth stating plainly:

- ◆ **No turn order.** Nobody waits for initiative. You act when the fiction hands you the spotlight; the enemy hurts you through your failed and partial rolls, and through the GM's framing when you stall or hide (see Timing, below).
- ◆ **Taking a foe out.** Enemies are adversaries with a **Resistance** pool (Part Fourteen). You don't track their wounds — you reduce that pool with your successes until it reaches 0, and then they break the way the fiction wants: dead, fled, surrendered, or cowed. Declare what you're trying to make happen; the same statline serves a kill or a capture.
- ◆ **Range and position are fiction.** Close in and a cutlass (Brave) is the tool; hold the distance and a pistol (Hunt) is. Tags carry the tactics — **Reload** buys the enemy a moment to close, **Ranged** lets you hurt what can't yet hurt you, **Brutal** and **Piercing** crack a tough target. Getting into the right position is the clever play that steps your difficulty down.
- ◆ **Ganging up & helping.** Numbers and teamwork show up as **difficulty**, not extra dice — an ally setting it up, a flanking angle, a distraction can step a Risky strike to Standard. A pack or a squad is one Resistance, not a crowd to be counted.
- ◆ **Fighting hurt.** Blood fallout — *Winded, Limping, Broken* (Part Four) — is the price of staying in too long. You can push through it, but the tracks fill and the D12 is always watching. Knowing when to break off is a skill the Shackles teaches the hard way.
- ◆ **Surrender, capture, mercy.** Not every fight ends in a body. Foes surrender or flee at Resistance 0; so can you. Being taken alive — a press-gang, a Chelish boarding — is a story, not a game over: the *Indentured, Seized, or Bounty* fallout made flesh.

Full adversary rules and a bestiary are in Part Fourteen; ship-scale battle is Part Ten.

## TIMING: NO ROUNDS, NO INITIATIVE

Play is paced by the fiction, not by a clock. There are **no rounds, no turns, and no initiative order** — at any scale, including ship-to-ship engagements. Adversaries never "take a turn." They inflict stress through your results (your failures and partial successes) and through the GM's framing when you stall, hide, or do nothing.

## THE FOUR GATES

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Every recurring ability is limited by exactly one of these — no other gating currencies exist:

- ◆ **Once per situation** — a single contiguous scene of pressure (a fight, a storm, a negotiation, a delicate job). It ends when the pressure breaks; the GM calls the boundary.
- ◆ **Once per session** — one real-world sitting of play.
- ◆ **Once per journey** — the whole passage between two landmarks, however many sessions it takes.
- ◆ **Once per campaign** — a single use across the entire campaign, never refreshed. Where a zenith grants the surviving party a once-per-campaign effect, that single use belongs to the party.

## LEGAL DURATIONS

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Timed effects are scoped to the fiction, never to a number of rounds: *"your next action," "until you next act," "until the end of the situation," "until the end of the session," "until you next make landfall,"* or a fictional condition such as *"while you remain still"* or *"until someone acts on it."* If an effect needs to repeat — a fire spreading, a storm battering a hull, poison working through a body — it repeats through **results**: those caught in it mark the listed stress when they fail or partially succeed against it, and whenever the GM judges it simply finds them.

## READING YOUR GEAR

You don't track coins or count shots. A piece of equipment is just a **stress die** (how big a hit it lands or heals) and maybe a **tag**. No suitable gear means a **D4**. The ladder runs **D4** improvised · **D6** civilian · **D8** professional · **D10** exotic · **D12** legendary. The tags you'll meet in a starting kit:

- ◆ **Brutal** — roll two stress dice, keep the highest.
- ◆ **Piercing** — ignores armour (Blood protection).
- ◆ **Ranged** — works at a distance. **Reload** — needs reloading between shots, so the enemy gets a moment.
- ◆ **Tiring** — its die drops a step when you fail with it.
- ◆ **Block** — +1 Blood protection (the only gear that adds protection).
- ◆ **Wyrd** — roll the max and you mark Tide; the deep noticed.

*(The full equipment, quality, and resource rules are in the System Reference.)*

# THE FIVE TRACKS

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Stress is the toll the Shackles takes — not a health bar, but the slow accumulation of pain, bad luck, supernatural attention, and lost coin. Every character carries five tracks. The GM marks stress to whichever one the *fiction* points at, and when a track's fallout fires, something concrete goes wrong. Four of the five can be cleared. One cannot — not until it collects.

## BLOOD *The body*

Wounds, exhaustion, fire, drowning, and the shock that lives in the flesh.

**FALLOUT LOOKS LIKE** — *Winded, Bleeding, Broken* (a bone — useless until a surgeon sees it).

**CLEARs BY** — Rest, food, and a surgeon.

## TIDE *The supernatural got in*

Ruins, rites, bargains, the deep paying attention — the rarest and most frightening track.

**FALLOUT LOOKS LIKE** — *Salt Weeping, The Mark, Compulsion* — something must be done, or avoided.

**CLEARs BY** — The hardest — ritual, or a full arc of story. Rest does nothing.

## REPUTATION *Your name*

Being bested where it's seen, breaking the Code, a story that travels ahead of you.

**FALLOUT LOOKS LIKE** — *Whispers, Bounty, Name Destroyed* in a stretch of the Shackles.

**CLEARs BY** — Public, witnessed deeds; standing the room a round; your bonds.

## LUCK *Fated misfortune*

The universe collecting on audacity, recklessness, and the loose ends you leave behind.

**FALLOUT LOOKS LIKE** — *Foreboding*, then *Crisis*; *The Tab* — a forgotten debt come due.

**CLEARs BY** — **Nothing but its own fallout firing.** The track that does not forgive.

## **GOLD** *Your material position*

Coin, a prize lost, a bribe paid, gear broken, a debt called in at the worst moment.

**FALLOUT LOOKS LIKE** — *Light Pockets, Broke, Marked for Collection.*

**CLEARs BY** — Plunder, a good prize, a debt settled.

# SKILLS & DOMAINS

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A **skill** is what you can do; a **domain** is where you know it and who you know there. When one is relevant, add a die and keep the highest. Both apply? Roll two. Gain either a second time and you get a **knack** — roll that narrow thing with mastery (an extra die). The combination is the character: *Tend* + *Deepwater* is a ship's surgeon; *Tend* + *Ruins* patches people up in collapsing Ghol-Gan chambers.

## BRAVE

Act in danger, brawl, hold your nerve.

## CAROUSE

Drink, gamble, work the social theatre of port.

## COMMAND

Lead, intimidate, inspire — move people.

## DECEIVE

Lie, cheat, forge, disguise, bluff.

## ENDURE

Resist punishment, exposure, disease, the sea.

## HUNT

Track, pursue, and end things, with skill.

## NAVIGATE

Chart courses, read weather, pilot, read tides.

## PLUNDER

Board, break in, loot — fast and bold.

## RECKON

Observe, deduce, read what's really happening.

## TEND

Heal, maintain gear, run ship systems, brew.



## VANISH

Hide, shadow, slip away, conceal.

## DEEPWATER

The open ocean, sea-monsters, storms, and the deep.

## SHALLOWS

Reefs, coastlines, tidal caves, hidden anchorages.

## PORT

Taverns, markets, dockside politics and crime.

## OUTLAW

The Code, Free Captain politics, smuggling, pirate culture.

## COLONIAL

Cheliox, the guilds, and the powers you exist to rob.

## ARCANE

Sea-magic, curses, witch-pacts, things older than ships.

## FAITH

Gods, cults, omens, and the religious life of the sea.

## RUINS

Ghol-Gan and pre-human sites, and what's buried below.

## WILDERNESS

Jungle interiors, island ecosystems, and survival.

# CALLINGS — WHY YOU SAIL

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Your calling is your reason for sailing — the obsession that keeps you from a quiet life ashore. It is not a class, a background, or a profession; it is closer to a wound that has organised itself into a direction. The calling tells you what your character cannot stop wanting. Everything else follows from that.

Every calling in this set is something the character *chose to sail with*. Nobody here is a pirate by sentence or by penance — the Shackles are entered by choice, and the tragedy is that the choice was real.

## THE SET

Everyone holds the shared **Piracy** calling alongside one personal calling:

| CALLING                   | THE ARC                                                      | DOMINANT TRACK                   |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| <b>Hunger</b>             | The chase — the wanting that the prize never fills           | Luck / Gold                      |
| <b>Monument</b>           | The build — making something that outlasts you               | Reputation                       |
| <b>Vendetta</b>           | The hunt of one — a single account to settle                 | Blood                            |
| <b>Freedom</b>            | The unfinished escape — every cage is yours to break         | Blood                            |
| <b>Cursed Tides</b>       | The claim — the sea has marked you for its own               | Tide                             |
| <b>Legacy</b>             | The inheritance — a name that went to sea before you         | Reputation                       |
| <b>Fellowship</b>         | The bond tested — the crew is the only wealth you count      | Luck                             |
| <b>Piracy</b><br>(shared) | The crew's story — a campaign-length arc for the whole table | Blood / Gold / Luck / Reputation |

## HOW CALLINGS WORK

Each calling grants a **core ability**, four **character questions**, and **beats**. At the end of each session, choose **two active beats** from your personal calling or the shared Piracy calling — the pools are combined. When you hit a beat, take an advance from your

class at the appropriate level. You can hold only two active beats at a time, and you cannot hit more than one in a single situation.

- ◆ **Minor beats** resolve within a session — the texture of the life (Act One).
- ◆ **Major beats** take two or three sessions — the turning points (Act Two).
- ◆ **Zenith beats** begin the end: one or two sessions remain for that character (Act Three). Every calling offers two zeniths — one fulfilment, one inversion — and neither is named or privileged over the other.

Beats that cost you something are **invitations, not punishments**: in selecting one, you are directing your character's story, not playing your character. A character does not know they have beats.

## THE DOWNFALL

Every personal calling's endings include the **Downfall**: the specific collapse that this obsession was always pointing toward. It is never required, and it is not a failure state. In the Shackles, it is often the most honest ending available. The shared Piracy calling has its own pair of campaign-ending zeniths — and no downfall of its own, because the life does not end; people do.

## WHAT YOU CARRY

Each calling ends in a **d10 table of objects**. They are not equipment — no bonuses, no slots. They are evidence of the life that brought you here, and they should invite questions you do not have to answer yet. Roll, or choose.

## CHOOSING YOUR CALLING

If you are torn between two callings, the question tells you which one fits.

- ◆ **Hunger or Vendetta?** If your target surrendered what they took but walked away free — enough? Yes: Hunger. No, you need to look them in the eye: Vendetta.
- ◆ **Hunger or Monument?** Hunger consumes and moves on; Monument keeps and builds. Is the question what is over the horizon, or what you will leave behind?
- ◆ **Hunger or Cursed Tides?** Could you stop? A Hunger character could, in principle. A Cursed Tides character is pulled whether they consent or not.
- ◆ **Hunger or Legacy?** Begin with nothing and take it, or begin holding something you never earned.
- ◆ **Monument or Legacy?** Monument constructs weight from nothing; Legacy inherits weight and must decide what to do with it.
- ◆ **Monument or Fellowship?** Which would you sacrifice first — the friendship or the structure? Monument keeps people because they are useful; Fellowship keeps them because they are irreplaceable.
- ◆ **Vendetta or Freedom?** If the target died tomorrow: grief at a lost purpose is Vendetta; getting back to work is Freedom. One points at a person, the other at a system.
- ◆ **Freedom or Fellowship?** Freedom burns a stranger's cage on principle; Fellowship counts the cost to these specific people first. Both are generous — differently.
- ◆ **Freedom or Cursed Tides?** One refuses every claim; the other is already claimed. (In a single character, this contradiction is fuel, not a problem.)
- ◆ **Cursed Tides or Legacy?** Can you negotiate with it? A legacy can be refused, honoured, or transformed. The call cannot.
- ◆ **Legacy or Vendetta?** Vendetta has a heading; Legacy has ballast. One is in pursuit, the other under weight.

- ◆ **Legacy or Fellowship?** The dead, or the living. Legacy faces what came before; Fellowship faces who is here.

## HUNGER

*There is always another horizon, and behind it the thing you actually want. You tell yourself this one is the last one. The sea is wide, the take is never enough, and somewhere out there is the prize that will finally fill you up. It won't.*

### CORE ABILITY

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**ONE MORE THROW.** You have never once accepted the first no. Once per session, after failing a roll in pursuit of something you want, reroll it. If you fail again, the incoming stress steps up one size.

When you create your character, answer these questions:

- ◆ What are you hunting, and what have you already spent on it?
- ◆ Choose another player character. You nearly died together going after something. What was it, and who pulled who out?
- ◆ Choose another player character. What do they own that you cannot stop noticing?
- ◆ Which rival is on the same trail, and how far ahead are you?

### MINOR BEATS

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- ◆ Take Minor Luck fallout.
- ◆ Take Minor Gold fallout.
- ◆ Steal something while its owner watches.
- ◆ Follow a rumour to a Tier 2 landmark or deeper.
- ◆ Sell or sacrifice a D8 or higher resource to keep the trail warm.
- ◆ Beat a rival to a prize by hours.
- ◆ Shake on a deal you can't honour.

- ◆ Refuse pay you badly need.
- ◆ Spend your last reserve at the worst moment.
- ◆ Acquire a bond who deals in maps, secrets or stolen goods.
- ◆ Tell another PC the whole history of what you hunt.
- ◆ Walk into obvious danger because the prize might be there.
- ◆ Stand somewhere no one on the crew has stood.
- ◆ Learn that something you carry is worth more than you knew.
- ◆ Promise another PC a share to get them aboard a bad idea.
- ◆ Keep a worthless thing you cannot explain keeping.
- ◆ Give away something the moment you finally hold it.
- ◆ Win a haggle you had no business winning.
- ◆ Come back to a place you knew and find it changed beyond recognition.
- ◆ Get caught red-handed.

## MAJOR BEATS

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- ◆ Take Major Luck fallout.
- ◆ Claim a prize that significant opposition guarded.
- ◆ Sell or sacrifice a D12 resource to learn what waits ahead.
- ◆ Reach a Tier 3 landmark that appears on no reliable chart.
- ◆ Betray an ally for a bigger share.
- ◆ Lose the most valuable thing you own.
- ◆ Learn the prize is cursed, guarded or worse than the stories — and keep going.
- ◆ Hold something the Aspis Consortium will kill to recover.
- ◆ Arrive at last, and find someone got there first.
- ◆ Get another PC to the thing they hunt, at real cost to you.

## ZENITH BEATS

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- ◆ Claim the thing you have hunted, and pay whatever it asks.
- ◆ Reach it at last — and turn away with empty hands.

Roll 1d10 on the following table or choose to determine what you carry with you to mark your calling:

1. Brass compass that doesn't point north
2. Lockpicks worn smooth with use
3. Chart of a place no official map shows, annotated in three hands
4. Coin from a mint that no longer exists
5. Letter of provenance for an item you don't own yet
6. List of everyone who hunted it before you, with notes on how they ended
7. Treasure map you drew yourself as bait, and have started to believe
8. Spyglass with a cracked lens you refuse to replace
9. Wax-sealed clay jar, contents unknown
10. Three maps of the same coastline that don't agree

## MONUMENT

*Most pirates take. You are making something — out of ships, stories, favours and fear — and every port that knows your name is a course of bricks laid true. One day the work will stand without you. The trick is living long enough to step back and see it.*

## CORE ABILITY

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**BRICK BY BRICK.** You strive to live up to the thing you are building. When you gain a minor advance, refresh D6. When you gain a major advance, refresh D8.



When you create your character, answer these questions:

- ◆ What are you building, and what do you call it in your honest moments?
- ◆ Choose another player character. They hold up part of the structure without knowing it. What part?
- ◆ Choose another player character. They knew you when you were nobody. What do you need from them now?
- ◆ Which port already tells a story about you, and how wrong is it?

## MINOR BEATS

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- ◆ Take Minor Reputation fallout.
- ◆ Be mistaken for something greater than you are.
- ◆ Publicly humiliate a rival, effortlessly.
- ◆ Make a speech meant for the retelling.
- ◆ Hear your story told by someone who doesn't know you're listening.
- ◆ Refuse to retreat — the ground is yours now.
- ◆ Show mercy because the story of it is worth more than the kill.
- ◆ Have a ship change course at the sight of your flag.
- ◆ Donate a D8 or higher resource to a haunt, loudly.
- ◆ Take credit for another pirate's work.
- ◆ Plant influence in a port you've never held: a favour, a debt, a flag.
- ◆ Dictate terms to someone holding the upper hand.
- ◆ Acquire a bond who owes you something they can't repay.
- ◆ Describe the finished work to another PC.
- ◆ Choose a person over the structure, and let a brick fall.
- ◆ Find your name somewhere you never put it.
- ◆ Pick a side in a port dispute because the outcome serves the work.
- ◆ Hear yourself used as the measure of someone else.

- ◆ Pay to make a story go away.
- ◆ Commission a song, a broadsheet or a rumour about yourself.

## MAJOR BEATS

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- ◆ Take Major Reputation fallout.
- ◆ Enter an enemy power's records: a Chelish mandate, an Aspis dossier.
- ◆ Win formal recognition from the Free Captains or the Pirate Council.
- ◆ Take and hold a berth, a route or an allegiance against opposition.
- ◆ Upgrade a haunt to D10 or higher and put your name on it.
- ◆ Make another PC load-bearing, and tell them what that means.
- ◆ Watch a piece of the structure fall in public.
- ◆ Learn that someone you trusted has been hollowing the walls.
- ◆ Be offered legitimacy — marque, pardon, seat — and decide if it's a brick or a trap.
- ◆ Win the thing you reached for, and feel the foundation crack beneath it.

## ZENITH BEATS

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- ◆ Step back from what you built, and watch it stand without you.
- ◆ Tear it down yourself, before anyone else can take it.

Roll 1d10 on the following table or choose to determine what you carry with you to mark your calling:

1. Flag of your own design, never yet flown
2. Custom seal and a stick of black wax
3. Ship's manifest naming you owner of a vessel you don't yet possess
4. Bundle of captains' debts tied in red cord
5. Broadsheet about you, wrong in three ways you've never corrected
6. Ledger of your deeds, with dates and witnesses

7. Portrait of you, commissioned at great expense, that doesn't quite look like you
8. The Pirate Code, annotated with your corrections
9. Key to a lock you haven't found yet
10. An unsigned proclamation you are not yet ready to make

## VENDETTA

*They took something from you that cannot be replaced, and they are still breathing. Every prize you take is practice; every port is a place they might be. You will look them in the eye before the end. What happens after that, you have never once let yourself imagine.*

## CORE ABILITY

---

**NOT WHILE THEY BREATHE.** You do not get to fall — not before they do. Once per session, activate this ability to avoid suffering negative effects from Blood or Reputation fallout for the remainder of the situation.

When you create your character, answer these questions:

- ◆ Who are they, what did they take, and how long ago?
- ◆ Choose another player character. They stopped you once, an inch from revenge or ruin. Which was it?
- ◆ Choose another player character. They know the whole story. Why them?
- ◆ What do you carry or wear that your target would recognise on sight?

## MINOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Minor Blood fallout.
- ◆ Find someone who knows your target personally.
- ◆ Cost your target something: property, standing, a good lieutenant.
- ◆ Refuse an offered settlement.

- ◆ Learn something that makes your target more human.
- ◆ Put another PC in danger for the vendetta's sake.
- ◆ Meet someone else they hurt.
- ◆ Lie to an ally about where you're leading them.
- ◆ Acquire a bond who feeds you intelligence.
- ◆ Leave a message your target cannot mistake.
- ◆ Chase a lead into waters deeper than the crew agreed to sail.
- ◆ Tell another PC, in full, what was taken.
- ◆ Let hatred make the decision.
- ◆ Hear that your target knows you're coming.
- ◆ Serve someone else's grievance to feed your own.
- ◆ Spend a D8 or higher resource on a lead that dies.
- ◆ Show a mercy your target never would.
- ◆ Rehearse what you'll say when you find them.
- ◆ Learn your target has grown stronger since you started.

## MAJOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Major Blood fallout.
- ◆ Destroy a major asset of your target: flagship, stronghold, heir.
- ◆ Fall into your target's hands.
- ◆ Learn something that genuinely complicates the hate.
- ◆ Lasting harm lands on another PC or a bond because of your hunt.
- ◆ Turn down a clean way to end it without facing them.
- ◆ Find out someone hunts you the way you hunt them.
- ◆ Your target strikes first, and the crew bleeds for it.
- ◆ Ally with someone you despise against the common enemy.
- ◆ Win a real victory over them that changes nothing.

## ZENITH BEATS

---

- ◆ Face your target at last, and settle the account.
- ◆ With your target finally in your power, let them go.

Roll 1d10 on the following table or choose to determine what you carry with you to mark your calling:

1. A scar they gave you, never properly treated
2. Loaded pistol kept for one purpose; it has a name you tell no one
3. Their ship's name carved into driftwood
4. List of their allies and ports, kept current in your own hand
5. A letter to them you never sent, explaining everything
6. Court documents proving the wrong, that no court will hear
7. Something of theirs — taken, not given
8. A sketch of their face good enough to find them in any disguise
9. The only surviving piece of what was taken from you
10. A knotted cord counting the days since

## FREEDOM

*Someone owned you once — by law, by debt, by force — and you remember exactly what it weighed. Now you are salt and open water, and every cage you meet is yours to break. You call it principle. Some nights it feels more like the chain, still pulling.*

## CORE ABILITY

---

**NEVER AGAIN.** You carried the weight once. Never again. Once per session, allocate stress you would mark to the nearest friendly target — PC or NPC — instead of marking it yourself.

When you create your character, answer these questions:

- ◆ Who held the leash, and what do they still hold — papers, family, a price on you?
- ◆ How did you get free, and who didn't make it out with you?
- ◆ Choose another player character. One of you freed the other. Which way around, and what's owed?
- ◆ Choose another player character. They've watched you risk the whole crew for a stranger in chains. What did they say?

## MINOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Minor Blood fallout.
- ◆ Free a prisoner, thrall or pressed sailor.
- ◆ Refuse a direct order from someone you respect.
- ◆ Burn a contract, writ or bill of sale.
- ◆ Be caught, bound or held — briefly.
- ◆ Meet someone who loves their cage.
- ◆ Tell another PC what your captivity was like.
- ◆ Acquire a bond you freed, or who freed you.
- ◆ Walk away from shelter because of its conditions.
- ◆ Stand with strangers you owe nothing.
- ◆ Turn down good coin to stay your own master.
- ◆ Say what you escaped, in front of those who profit by it.
- ◆ Help another PC refuse what they'd already accepted.
- ◆ Light a mutiny, a strike or a small rebellion aboard any vessel.
- ◆ Take on a debt to break someone else's.
- ◆ Step between a cruelty you know and its target.
- ◆ Destroy a slaver's ledger worth D8 or more rather than sell it.
- ◆ Find the leash hidden inside something you chose freely.

- ◆ Hide a runaway through a port inspection.

## MAJOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Major Blood fallout.
- ◆ Take a vessel and hand it to its own crew.
- ◆ Burn a slaving operation or press-gang network out of a port.
- ◆ Be recaptured — long enough to cost something real — and break out.
- ◆ Refuse power because of what you'd have to hold to keep it.
- ◆ Free someone who does something unforgivable with it.
- ◆ Stand before the one who owned you.
- ◆ Buy another PC's freedom without being asked.
- ◆ Learn your price has been bought by someone new.
- ◆ Open a chartered route that runaways can sail without you.

## ZENITH BEATS

---

- ◆ Bring down the person or institution that owned you, and stand in the ashes.
- ◆ Sail beyond every claim on you — law, debt and name — and do not come back.

Roll 1d10 on the following table or choose to determine what you carry with you to mark your calling:

1. Half a broken manacle, worn on a cord
2. Freedom papers, expertly forged
3. Their brand, reworked by your own hand into something else
4. Songbook from captivity, in handwriting that isn't yours
5. List of the names still inside
6. A key from the one who held you; it fits nothing you've found
7. The bill for your own purchase, paid in full — you got yourself at a discount
8. Map of where you were held, drawn from memory, every door correct

9. A small thing you were forbidden to have
10. The scrap of paper where someone first wrote your name instead of your number

## CURSED TIDES

*When you sleep, you dream of deep water, and the dreams are getting accurate. Something beneath the waves has marked you for its own — Besmara, or a thing older than her flag. You sail because it calls you, and because staying ashore feels like drowning slowly.*

### CORE ABILITY

---

**SALT IN THE VEINS.** The sea keeps what it has tasted. +1 Tide protection. Once per situation, when you would mark stress to any other resistance, you may mark it to Tide instead.

When you create your character, answer these questions:

- ◆ When did the sea first speak to you, and what did it cost to listen?
- ◆ How has the call marked your body?
- ◆ Choose another player character. They watched you obey the water once. What did they see?
- ◆ Choose another player character. The sea showed you something about them. Why haven't you told them?

### MINOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Minor Tide fallout.
- ◆ Heed a warning nothing natural could have given, and be right.
- ◆ Eat or drink something of the deep.
- ◆ Let something in that a port had kept out.
- ◆ Unsettle an NPC with the way you speak about water.



- ◆ Perform a rite at a place of power, Tier 2 or deeper.
- ◆ Speak with something below the surface.
- ◆ Name the thing that calls you, and use only that name from now on.
- ◆ Wake somewhere you don't remember sailing.
- ◆ Spare a thing of the deep you could have killed.
- ◆ Meet something from your dreams while awake.
- ◆ Sink, float or lash a shrine to the water.
- ◆ Call a course on faith alone, and be right.
- ◆ Acquire a bond sworn to Besmara or the deep.
- ◆ Obey the tide against your own interest.
- ◆ Gain a mark that changes with the moon.
- ◆ Find the wakes of others who were called, and how they ended.
- ◆ Hide someone else the sea has touched.
- ◆ Stay ashore through the call's worst night, for someone else's sake.
- ◆ Refuse the call once, and feel what it takes in exchange.

## MAJOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Major Tide fallout.
- ◆ Perform a rite in a drowned ruin, Tier 3 or deeper, and receive something.
- ◆ Give the tide something you love.
- ◆ Show an outsider what calls you; watch them break, believe or run.
- ◆ A bond suffers fallout because of what follows you.
- ◆ Be recognised by something of the deep.
- ◆ Follow the call into uncharted waters (this adds D12 to the journey's resistance).
- ◆ Be claimed by Besmara's church, or the cults of the Eye, as one of theirs.
- ◆ Scuttle a safe anchorage because the tide required it.
- ◆ Meet another who was called, and answered differently.

## ZENITH BEATS

---

- ◆ Answer the call in full: go beneath, and do not return as anything the world knows.
- ◆ Tear the sea's claim out of yourself, and live with the silence it leaves.

Roll 1d10 on the following table or choose to determine what you carry with you to mark your calling:

1. Coral that grew around your wrist while you slept; it grows back
2. Water-ruined journal of visions; the legible pages are worse
3. Warm timber from a ship lost with all hands
4. A polite note declining your last offering — you haven't told anyone the sea writes
5. Tattoo of a creature you have met only in dreams
6. A page in your own hand, in no script you know
7. Rope that cannot be cut, in a knot you don't remember tying
8. A tooth that matches no bestiary
9. Mirror that runs half a second behind
10. A name that isn't yours, burned into the sole of your foot

## LEGACY

*Your name went to sea before you did. Somebody of your blood did something these islands still remember, and every port has already decided who you are. The legacy is a door, a debt and a loaded gun. The one thing it has never been is yours.*

## CORE ABILITY

---

**IN THEIR FOOTSTEPS.** You have watched this done — in stories, in dreams, in blood. Gain one skill your ancestor was known for. Once per session, before you roll dice to resolve an action, instead state that your result is a 6. You succeed but take stress.

When you create your character, answer these questions:

- ◆ Who came before you, and what did they do that the sea still remembers?
- ◆ What do strangers expect of you on hearing your name?
- ◆ Choose another player character. Your families' stories are tangled — debt, rescue or crime. Which, and who knows?
- ◆ Choose another player character. They treat you differently since learning the name. How?

## MINOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Minor Reputation fallout.
- ◆ Be recognised for the name before the face.
- ◆ Hear something about your ancestor you'd rather not know.
- ◆ Catch yourself making their famous decision.
- ◆ Refuse a piece of the inheritance.
- ◆ Take up a piece of it you once refused.
- ◆ Make amends to someone your blood wronged.
- ◆ Be turned away for something done before your birth.
- ◆ Recover a record, a chart or a D8 or higher resource of your line.
- ◆ Learn the famous deed was a lie.
- ◆ Gain a follower because of who you come from.
- ◆ Do what your line would never do, and say so aloud.
- ◆ Meet the heirs or creditors of your family's victims.
- ◆ Claim passage, berth or credit on the name alone.
- ◆ Tell another PC how your ancestor ended.
- ◆ Keep a family custom that costs you.
- ◆ Find a stranger wearing your family's name.
- ◆ Quiet a room by saying who you are.

- ◆ Acquire a bond who served your line, and expects.
- ◆ Sail a route your family charted, and pay its toll.

## MAJOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Major Reputation fallout.
- ◆ Assume a role or burden the line is known for.
- ◆ Face the living consequence of the famous deed.
- ◆ Be disowned or denounced by those who claimed your blood.
- ◆ Unearth the line's buried truth: a crime, a bargain, an heir.
- ◆ Make the choice your ancestor couldn't.
- ◆ End a piece of the legacy forever: the debt, the feud, the flag.
- ◆ Another PC suffers fallout from a feud your blood began.
- ◆ Reclaim a family right, and find it dearer to hold than to win.
- ◆ Begin something your own heirs will have to carry.

## ZENITH BEATS

---

- ◆ Become the one the line is remembered by, eclipsing all who came before.
- ◆ Pay the line's last debt, burn its flag, and sail out from under the name.

Roll 1d10 on the following table or choose to determine what you carry with you to mark your calling:

1. A signet that opens doors it shouldn't
2. Their portrait, with your face in it
3. The log of their last voyage, ending mid-sentence
4. An ancestral debt, still legally valid; the collectors persist
5. Their undelivered letter, memorised
6. A worthless object they treasured, given to you without explanation
7. Their weapon, repaired into technically a different weapon — except it isn't

8. A deed to something someone else currently holds
9. Their uncracked cipher; you've worked it for years
10. Their name, tattooed on you before you could refuse

## FELLOWSHIP

*Other pirates sail for gold or glory. You sail for the faces around the watch-lantern — these people, this ship, this unrepeatable luck. They are the only wealth you have ever counted. The sea knows exactly how to hurt you, and one day it will.*

## CORE ABILITY

---

**THE BODY BETWEEN.** What hits them hits you first, if you're fast enough. Once per session, when another PC or named crewmember within reach marks stress, you may mark it instead of them.

When you create your character, answer these questions:

- ◆ Choose another player character. You would die for them without a thought. What made it true — and do they know?
- ◆ Choose another player character. You failed them once, badly. What changed in you?
- ◆ Who did you lose before this crew, and what of theirs do you still carry?
- ◆ The ports say this crew holds together because of you. What did people see that started that story?

## MINOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Minor Luck fallout.
- ◆ Put your body between a crewmate and harm.
- ◆ Learn a secret a crewmate has told no one.
- ◆ Share true rest with the crew: a meal, a calm watch, a shore night.

- ◆ Make the call the crew hates, and carry the friction.
- ◆ Quietly cover another PC's mistake.
- ◆ Acquire a bond who becomes family, not contact.
- ◆ Pass up a windfall that would mean leaving someone.
- ◆ Tell a crewmate the truth they didn't want.
- ◆ Cheer another PC's victory louder than your own.
- ◆ Grieve for one of the crew's dead.
- ◆ Take blame that wasn't yours.
- ◆ Be seen at your worst by the people you hold up.
- ◆ Fight with a crewmate over values, not tactics.
- ◆ Keep everyone moving while everything burns.
- ◆ Fail someone who needed you, and face them.
- ◆ Suffer fallout from stress you took for someone else.
- ◆ Vouch for a stranger with your own standing.
- ◆ Pay a crew debt out of your own share, silently.
- ◆ Be caught keeping count of everything that could take them.

## MAJOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Major Luck fallout.
- ◆ Save a crewmate when the sensible call was letting go.
- ◆ Lose one of the crew for good.
- ◆ Learn something that tests your loyalty to its limit.
- ◆ Hold the crew together through shipwreck, mutiny or massacre.
- ◆ Tear the crew apart, and mend what you tore.
- ◆ Give up safety, fortune or freedom so the crew keeps theirs.
- ◆ Take back someone who truly wronged you.
- ◆ Refuse honours that would split the crew.

- ◆ Build something with them that outlasts the voyage: a code, a tradition, a haunt of your own.

## ZENITH BEATS

---

- ◆ Give everything you have, in one moment, so the crew sails on.
- ◆ Outlive them — scattered, sunk or sailed on — and carry what remains.

Roll 1d10 on the following table or choose to determine what you carry with you to mark your calling:

1. Small things they gave you, kept secretly together
2. A letter never sent, added to for months
3. Every name you've ever sailed with, one word beside each
4. A carved figure of a crewmate, never shown
5. A dead crew's tradition, kept alone
6. A scar a friend gave you and doesn't know about
7. An old crew's song, sung badly, alone
8. The crew's accounts, quietly balanced from your own share for years
9. Something of the lost one's, worn out of sight
10. A memorial of this crew's deeds, written for whoever reads it after you

## PIRACY

*The ship, the sea, the prize, the port, the Code. Whatever else drives you, this is the life you all chose, and it keeps its own ledger. Every crew gets a story. The sea decides how long it runs; you decide what it is about.*

Every character holds Piracy alongside their personal calling. At the end of each session, choose two active beats from either pool.

When you create your crew, answer these questions together:

- ◆ What is your ship, and what did it cost to get her?
- ◆ What was the crew's first prize together, and what went wrong?
- ◆ Which port counts as home, and who there wishes you wouldn't?
- ◆ What enemy already knows your flag?

## MINOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Minor Blood fallout.
- ◆ Take Minor Gold fallout.
- ◆ Take Minor Luck fallout.
- ◆ Take Minor Reputation fallout.
- ◆ Survive a storm, a rogue wave or the Eye's weather.
- ◆ Make the navigational call the crew must live with.
- ◆ Outrun a superior sail — or turn and face it.
- ◆ Board a prize and deal with what's actually aboard.
- ◆ Complete a journey through Tier 2 waters or deeper.
- ◆ Stand the night watch alone, and come in changed.
- ◆ Acquire a bond in a port: fence, keeper, harbourmaster.
- ◆ Be recognised for something you did — or didn't.
- ◆ Find trouble ashore that has nothing to do with your obsessions.
- ◆ Pass a port inspection with something to hide.
- ◆ Drink a port dry and stay welcome.
- ◆ Invoke the Code, win or lose.
- ◆ Share a dock with a rival crew without incident — barely.
- ◆ Be asked to do something the Code allows and your stomach doesn't.
- ◆ Watch the Free Captains' politics up close.
- ◆ Take a prize and learn what it's actually worth.



- ◆ Divide shares, and feel the division bite.
- ◆ Lose a prize to weather, pursuit or a fair decision.
- ◆ Sell loot to someone who knows where it came from.

## MAJOR BEATS

---

- ◆ Take Major Blood fallout, and keep sailing.
- ◆ Take Major Reputation fallout, as the Shackles reassesses you.
- ◆ Survive what should have killed you, with the crew watching.
- ◆ Draw the formal attention of the Chelish Navy, the Aspis Consortium or a rival Free Captain.
- ◆ Lose a ship.
- ◆ Make an enemy with the standing to matter.
- ◆ Tip the politics of the Shackles, even slightly.
- ◆ Gain or lose enough to change the ship's quality or a haunt's dice.
- ◆ Hear your deed told wrong in a port you've never visited.
- ◆ Choose between the Code and your own judgement, lastingly.

## ZENITH BEATS

---

- ◆ Carve the crew into the Shackles for good — a council seat, a free port, a flag that sails on without you.
- ◆ Lose the ship, the sea or each other, and scatter the way all crews end.

Roll 1d10 on the following table or choose to determine what you carry with you to mark your calling:

1. The crew's mark, tattooed somewhere you chose carefully
2. A share-token from your first prize, drilled and worn
3. Your copy of the articles, signed by every hand
4. Dice carved from the mast of a ship that didn't make it

5. A storm-glass that has never once been wrong
6. One of the three keys to the spirit locker
7. A pistol ball they dug out of you, kept as change
8. Your dead predecessor's hat — it fits
9. An IOU from the quartermaster, gathering interest
10. A chart of home waters, corrected in your own blood at least once

# CLASSES — WHAT YOU CAN DO

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Your class is the reason you are not dead yet. It is your particular expertise — the toolkit that has kept you alive through everything the Shackles has thrown at you so far. Where your **calling** is why you sail, your **class** is how you survive it.

## THE TEN CLASSES

| CLASS              | CORE SKILL · DOMAIN | IN A LINE                                                                          |
|--------------------|---------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Castaway</b>    | Endure · Wilderness | The wreck the wild Shackles kept and remade — a feral island survivor              |
| <b>Chronicler</b>  | Reckon · Ruins      | A scholar of drowned civilisations who reads ruins like open books                 |
| <b>Corsair</b>     | Brave · Deepwater   | A philosophy of controlled destruction; expensive to ignore                        |
| <b>Daredevil</b>   | Vanish · Outlaw     | Circus-trained escapologist who always has a way out                               |
| <b>Errant</b>      | Hunt · Colonial     | A formal duelist from somewhere with rules                                         |
| <b>Powder Mage</b> | Hunt · Arcane       | An arcane gunner channelling force through iron and smoke                          |
| <b>Sawbone</b>     | Tend · Deepwater    | The same saw opens a chest and cuts a plank — surgeon and ship's carpenter         |
| <b>Sharper</b>     | Deceive · Port      | The one who plays the game beneath the game                                        |
| <b>Sin Bosun</b>   | Navigate · Faith    | The ship's priest — found when someone is dying, and when the sky needs talking to |
| <b>Tidecaller</b>  |                     |                                                                                    |

| CLASS | CORE SKILL · DOMAIN | IN A LINE                                                     |
|-------|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
|       | Command · Arcane    | Bound by an unclear pact to something at the heart of the Eye |

## HOW A CLASS WORKS

Each class gives you a starting **skill**, **domain**, **resource**, and **equipment** (with a choice), then two **core abilities** you have from the start. As you hit calling beats, you take **advances** from your class:

- ◆ **Minor abilities** — most of your growth; a deep list to pick from, several repeatable.
- ◆ **Major abilities** — larger powers, each with sub-options (the indented **MINOR:** lines) you can take as later advances to deepen them.
- ◆ **Zenith abilities** — endgame powers. Taking one signals your character's story is reaching its conclusion; several are activated by your character's death or retirement and reshape the world around them.

## A NOTE ON BALANCE (VERSION 5)

These classes are the **Version 5** rebalance. Three rules were enforced across the whole set:

- ◆ **The combat floor** — combat is a protected axis; every class fights at par. Piracy is steel, smoke, and blood, so no class is a non-combatant.
- ◆ **Identity, not spikes** — each class has one clear proficiency and at most one neglect, unless an "extreme" is a deliberate, on-theme choice (the Powder Mage's glass-cannon gunnery; the Castaway's wordless feral edge; the Sharper's information web; the Chronicler's drowned-lore scholarship).

- ◆ **Healing spread** — party medicine is shared across five classes (Castaway, Corsair, Tidecaller, Sin Bosun, and the Sawbone), rather than concentrated on one. The Sawbone has turned ship-ward — the vessel's surgeon-engineer.

## CASTAWAY

*The Shackles is a wild place, and it keeps the people it wrecks. Every island chain has its stories: the sailor who walked out of the interior two years after their ship went down, eating things no one could name, speaking a little less than they used to. These survivors are known as Castaways. The shipwreck was just how they arrived — what changed them was everything after. They ate what grew in the deep interior. They drank from springs beneath Ghol-Gan stonework. They slept in ruins because the stone held heat and the things in the trees did not come inside. And the wild Shackles, which does not care about names or flags or the Pirate Code, decided to keep them functional — remaking them, gradually and without explanation, into something more suitable. Castaways are prized aboard any ship that strays from the charted lanes. No chart, no pilot and no priest can tell you as much about an island as someone who has been eaten by one and come out the other side. They do not always come ashore willingly. But put them on a beach with a knife and a hungry interior ahead of them, and watch them become most completely themselves.*

## CORE TRAITS

---

- ◆ **SKILL:** Endure
- ◆ **DOMAIN:** Wilderness
- ◆ **RESOURCE:** A twist of dried meat from something that has no name yet D6 Wilderness

- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Scavenged knife Brave D6
  - ◆ Pick one:
    - ◆ Wreck-iron machete Brave D8, Brutal, Tiring
    - ◆ Poultices, fish-gut sutures and salvage-kit remedies Tend Blood D6
    - ◆ Harpoon and salvaged line Hunt D8, Ranged, Tiring

## CORE ABILITIES

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### ISLANDSBLOOD

*The wild places of the Shackles recognise you as one of their own; the further you get from civilisation, the harder you are to kill.* Your minimum protection value for all resistances is equal to the tier of your current location. This value doesn't add to other sources of protection, but your base protection can't be lower than your current tier unless you specifically lose access to it due to fallout.

Tiers are defined in **Location Tiers** (System Documents): regional danger from 0 (lawful waters) to 4 (the drowned places), with each step inland from the shore increasing the tier by one.

### THE RED FEAST

*Your changed guts pluck memories from the meat.* When you eat a resource, you gain any domains associated with that resource until the end of the situation. If you already have access to the domain, gain an appropriate knack. There's no limit to what you can eat, but tough or noxious materials might require an Endure+Wilderness check to avoid causing yourself harm. Consuming resources requires your attention and leaves you exposed, so doing it successfully in stressful situations (such as combat) could require a Vanish roll.



## MINOR ABILITIES

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### CRAB AND ROOT

*You learned medicine from an island pharmacopoeia that no physician has catalogued — and you can put a crewmate back together with it as readily as yourself.* Gain the Tend skill. You can treat Blood stress and fallout — your own or an ally's — without equipment or supplies, using whatever grows, crawls or seeps nearby. When you treat an ally this way, your Tend dice increases by one step.

### DESPERATE MEASURES

*You've eaten people. The longboat drifted for six weeks; you came ashore alone.* Gain the Deepwater domain. You can consume the flesh of something or someone that you have recently killed and gain a skill associated with them for the remainder of the situation.

### FERAL TRACKING

*Your survival depended on knowing exactly what else shared the island with you.* Gain the Hunt skill. Roll with mastery when you follow a trail, and you always know whether a trail was made deliberately or carelessly — which is usually the more important piece of information.

### GUT INSTINCT

Gain access to one of the following skills: Brave, Deceive, Endure, Hunt, Navigate, Plunder, Reckon, Tend, Vanish. You can take this advance more than once.

### INHUMAN

Gain +1 protection in the Blood, Tide, Reputation or Gold resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

### INTERIOR

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Arcane, Ruins, Wilderness. You can take this advance more than once.

## **RUIN-WALKER**

*The old stonework feels inhabited to you, and whatever inhabits it has decided you can stay.* Gain the Ruins domain. Once per session, when you shelter and rest in a ruin, refresh D4.

## **SALT-STILL**

*Things that hunt by motion taught you the value of perfect quiet.* Gain the Vanish skill. While you remain still in natural terrain — jungle, reef, shoreline, ruin — Vanish rolls are never considered Risky or Dangerous.

## **SCAVENGED ARSENAL**

*Your hands know what to make before your mind has finished the question.* Gain the Plunder skill. Improvised weapons you build or seize inflict D6 stress rather than D4. The results are ugly. They are exactly sufficient.

## **SPEAKING TO STRAYS**

*Whatever the island put in you, the animals can smell it too.* Gain the Arcane domain. Creatures of the wild Shackles treat you as adjacent kin — neither prey nor pack, simply present. Once per session, you can call on the local wildlife to create a distraction, carry a small object or throw an area into bestial chaos.

## **THE CHANGED PALATE**

*Food is fuel for the thing the island lit inside you.* Gain the Brave skill. When you use THE RED FEAST ability, you may choose to have your attacks gain the Brutal tag for a number of actions equal to the amount rolled on the resource dice instead of gaining a domain.

## **THE ISLAND'S CLAIM**

*Something that may be the island and may be something in the island intends to keep you functional.* Gain +2 Tide protection.

## WHAT THE ISLAND HARDENED

*Your body has adapted to conditions that should have killed it several times over. Gain +2 Blood protection.*

## MAJOR ABILITIES

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### BLOODBOUND BEAST

*You are accompanied by a ragged creature of the interior that follows your commands — a scarred jungle cat, a monitor lizard the size of a longboat, or something the island made specially. You feed it your blood, and it fights for you. You gain the Bloodbound tag on all weapons as you and your companion work in concert. - MINOR: PACK HUNTER. If you mark stress to Blood to activate the Bloodbound tag, roll with mastery when you use the Hunt and Vanish skills for the remainder of the current situation. - MINOR: POUNCE. Once per situation, select an adversary you can see. That adversary marks D6 stress as your companion leaps on them. - MINOR: FAITHFUL UNTIL THE END. If you take Critical fallout and would die, you do not die — instead, you are rescued by your companion and dragged to safety at the nearest landmark. Your companion dies in your arms, exhausted and wounded, after you regain consciousness. Remove BLOODBOUND BEAST from your character sheet and gain an immediate major advance. You can't access BLOODBOUND BEAST ever again.*

### WHAT CAME BACK

*With the sound of cracking muscle and twisting tendon, your body remembers what the island made of it. When you activate this power, mark D4 stress to Tide. For the remainder of the current situation, all melee attacks you make gain the Brutal and Wyrd tags. - MINOR: CORAL-HIDDEN. When you activate WHAT CAME BACK, increase the Tide stress inflicted by 1 step and gain +2 Blood protection until the end of the current situation in addition to any other effects. - MINOR: RAZORTOOTHED. When you activate WHAT CAME BACK, increase the Tide stress inflicted by 1 step and increase your melee damage by 1 step until the end of the*

current situation, in addition to any other effects. - MINOR: FERAL. When you activate WHAT CAME BACK, increase the Tide stress inflicted by 1 step and ignore the effects of Blood fallout until the end of the situation. You fight on, heedless of the pain.

## **LEVIATHAN LANCE**

*You carry an enormous harpoon-thrower of wreck-iron and whale-bone, built for prey that could swallow a longboat — the mark of someone who has hunted the things the deep sends up.* When you take this ability, you gain access to (or build) an enormous ranged weapon with the following profile: (Hunt D10, Tiring, Ranged, Expensive.) - MINOR: FAST-LINE. Once per situation, when you inflict stress on an adversary with the LEVIATHAN LANCE, you attach yourself to them with a rope or chain. They can't flee while attached — and neither can you. - MINOR: HUNTER'S EYE. Once per situation, when you and your allies are in danger, point out a tactically useful element of the landscape. The first time an ally interacts with the element, they roll with mastery on their subsequent action. - MINOR: SPLINTER SHOT. Gain access to the following weapon: (Hunt D8, Spread, Ranged, One-Shot).

## **MONSTROUS APPETITE**

*When you eat, you unhinge your jaw and wolf down anything within reach until your belly is distended and you are resplendent with power.* When you use THE RED FEAST to consume a resource that has a domain you can access, remove stress from Blood or Tide equal to the amount rolled on the dice instead. - MINOR: REJUVENATION. Once per session, when you use MONSTROUS APPETITE to consume a resource that has a domain that you have access to — and the resource has a value of D8 or higher — you can remove a Minor Blood or Tide fallout entirely. - MINOR: TAINTED MEAT. Once per session, when you use MONSTROUS APPETITE to consume a resource with the Arcane domain with a value of D8 or higher, add 1 to the minimum protection provided by your ISLANDSBLOOD core ability instead of removing stress. This effect lasts until the end of the situation. - MINOR: HORRENDOUS BITE. Once per situation, when you inflict stress with an

unarmed attack on an adversary, you may choose to lower their difficulty by one step to a minimum of Standard until the end of the situation.

## THE WILD HUNT

*The wild Shackles sings of flesh and plenty; you echo that sickening song.* You may lead a group in communion with the wild places. This requires you to pass an Endure+Wilderness roll, and the check is Risky if you're in a civilised or settled location (tier 0–1). (If you fail the check, you can try again later this session.) Those who commune gain the Hunt skill if they don't already have it, and increase the stress they inflict on journeys by 1 step until the end of the current journey. - MINOR: VOICES OF THE INTERIOR. When you use THE WILD HUNT, instead of the Hunt skill, you may grant the Navigate skill to participants. Pick which skill you grant each time you use the ability. - MINOR: STORYTELLER. Once per session, when you're tracking a beast, you can declare it to be a renowned beast — you've heard tell of it before. Tell the party what's so dangerous about it, or repeat a legend of its exploits. This increases the beast's protection by 1, its damage by 1 step and any resources gathered from it by 2 steps. - MINOR: BOUNTY SHARED. When you complete a journey or hunt and kill a renowned beast (see above), everyone who took part in THE WILD HUNT may remove D6 stress from Luck or Gold.

## ZENITH ABILITIES

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### LEVIATHAN

*You undergo the final change — you become something the deep trenches produce, vast and green-black and ruinous, and your approach empties harbours.* Following a transformation process that is either distressingly sudden or agonisingly slow, your flesh and bones burst and reform into those of a true leviathan of the deep. You are as powerful and ruinous as any terror the Eye has ever sent up, but you retain your will — for the remainder of the current situation, at least. After that, you slide beneath the water and are claimed by the deep, becoming another drowned god that will beset sailors in centuries to come.

## LEGENDARY BEAST

*You shed what little remains of your human form and ascend into something many-limbed and majestic. When you gain access to this ability, you begin your hunt to slay the Beast: the capital-B Beast, the oldest thing in the interior, a creature wrought from coral and muscle and petrified mangrove that was ancient when Ghol-Gan raised its first stone. You will kill the Beast, and in doing so, you understand it perfectly. You become the new Beast, an epitome of feral power and a legend whispered in every port. You become part of the wilderness of the Shackles; the interior grows around you more than ever, blossoming into patterns you dream of in the echoing recesses of your ancient gestalt mind. Create a new landmark — an island or interior that is your territory; here, you are lord and ruler, but you can no longer leave. One day, another Castaway will wash ashore, find you, kill you and become you.*

## ROOT AND RUIN

*Following the passing of a legendary survivor, sometimes the Interior — the green and waiting heart of every island, older than charts and indifferent to flags — surges out to claim their body as a prize. To activate this ability, die. The location you are currently occupying is overwhelmed by the wild: mangrove and strangler fig erupt through deck-planking and stonework, reefs rise where there was open water, swarms of bright and hungry creatures smash apart the world around them, and your body is subsumed into the black, fecund soil to be reborn. If you're on a journey, immediately establish a new landmark where you fell. This eruption will remain connected to the deep interior for a few hours before it is severed — then the growth will calcify into a dead garden of bleached coral, ill-auspiced and frequented only by gulls and ghosts. When you are reborn, you awaken in the Interior. You have an afterlife of hunting, feasting and listening to the green silence to look forward to.*

## CHRONICLER

*The Shackles has been drowning civilisations since before it had a name. Azlant sank whole. The cyclops empire of Ghol-Gan left its stonework on every island, geometries*

*that do not quite resolve into sense. Lirgen, nation of astrologers, watched the sky for a thousand years and never saw the Eye coming. The sea swallows them all, and the Eye grinds what remains into something half-preserved and half-destroyed — and you read what they left behind. You learned early what the colonial universities refuse to admit: that the magic you practise and the history you study are the same subject. A dead tradition is not gone. Its workings are still down there in the wrecks and the ruin-chambers, written in scripts no living person was supposed to read, waiting for someone with the patience to recover them and the nerve to speak them aloud. The other scholars call what you do grave-robbery. The grave-robbers call it scholarship. They are both correct, and neither of them can do what you do: stand in a drowned temple, read the wall, and make the past pick its tools back up.*

## CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Reckon
- ◆ DOMAIN: Ruins
- ◆ RESOURCE: A coin from an empire no living person can name D6 Ruins
- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Pick one:
  - ◆ Excavator's pick Plunder D8, Brutal, Tiring
  - ◆ Lantern-staff of salvaged Azlanti glass Brave D6; sheds clean light that needs no fuel
  - ◆ Field conservation kit and a pocket pistol Tend Gold D6; Hunt D6, Ranged, Reload

## CORE ABILITIES

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### THE ARCHIVE

*You carry an annotated spellbook that is also a historical record; to you these are the same document, and objects speak to you as readily as pages.* At character creation, establish one dead language you can read and one drowned civilisation that is your particular study — these are always available as knowledge, without rolls. When you

first encounter a ruin, wreck or significant relic, the GM tells you one true thing about its history and one true thing about its dangers. You also handle and conserve the past directly: gain the Tend skill, and once per session, when you handle a significant object with a minute's attention, you learn who made it, approximately when, what it was used for, and the most significant event it witnessed.

## **WHERE THE PAST LINGERS**

*The old places remember their own workings, and they recognise a practitioner.* When you are in a ruin, a wreck, or any place abandoned since before living memory, roll with mastery when you attempt to cast a spell.

## **MINOR ABILITIES**

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### **ACADEMIC NETWORK**

*You correspond with scholars, archivists and obsessives across the Inner Sea.* Gain the Colonial domain. Once per session, when you make port, a letter is waiting for you containing one piece of relevant historical intelligence. Your correspondents live in the colonial world; keeping them requires navigating its politics carefully.

### **COMPARATIVE STUDIES**

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Arcane, Ruins, Faith, Colonial. You can take this advance more than once.

### **THE DIG MAPPED**

*One eye on the chart of what drowned, one on what's worth pulling out of it.* Gain the Navigate skill. Once per session, when seeking a wreck, ruin or drowned settlement, ask the GM where to start looking, and they will tell you. When you reach a site, ask what the single most valuable thing you could extract is — and what extracting it will cost — and they will tell you.



## FIELD RESEARCH

Gain access to one of the following skills: Carouse, Deceive, Endure, Hunt, Navigate, Plunder, Reckon, Tend, Vanish. You can take this advance more than once.

## GRAVE GOODS

*The dead were buried with their power. They have stopped needing it.* Gain the Shallows domain. Before you cast a spell from this class, you can opt to destroy a resource with the Ruins domain. Roll the resource's dice; the amount rolled is added to your Protection value against any stress incurred as a result of casting the spell.

## THE EXCAVATOR'S ANSWER

*You have spent a career learning where old stone wants to break, where a sealed tomb's hinge is weakest, what a millennium does to bone. The same eye reads the things that guard those places.* Gain the Plunder skill. Your excavator's pick (and like tools) is a weapon in your hands. Against stone, bone, construct or undead — the things that haunt ruins and wrecks — your attacks gain the Piercing tag; you know exactly where the centuries left them weak.

## PRESERVATION

Gain +1 Protection in the Blood, Tide, Reputation or Gold resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

## PROVENANCE

*Every artefact is worth what its story says it is worth. You write excellent stories.* Gain the Deceive skill. Roll with mastery when you authenticate — or fabricate — the provenance of any artefact, relic or historical document.

## THE OLD WAY

*The god may be dead, but the working remembers.* Gain the Faith domain. Once per session, perform a rite from a dead faith: a small blessing, a temporary protection against supernatural harm, or words that a specific kind of spirit will stop and answer.

## TONGUE OF THE DEAD

*Ancient, dead and deliberately obscured scripts are your speciality.* Gain the Arcane domain. You can read any written language you have encountered before, and you can attempt any script you have never seen with a Reckon+Arcane roll.

## WARDED SCHOLAR

*Your body carries inscriptions copied faithfully from tombs that were never robbed.* Gain +2 Tide protection.

## WHAT KNOWLEDGE FETCHES

*There is always someone who will pay for what you know, and usually before the situation becomes critical.* Gain +2 Gold protection.

## MAJOR ABILITIES

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### THE SAOC STARMAPS

*Lirgen's astrologers read the sky for a thousand years. You recovered their charts from the Sodden Lands, and they still work — for whatever that proved to be worth.* Roll Reckon+Ruins to cast this spell beneath an open sky. On a success, ask the GM what significant event will occur within the next session relating to a topic you specify. The answer is specific, accurate and literal — and occasionally misleading in implication. The Saoc Brethren were never wrong. They were also all drowned. - MINOR: THE BROAD VIEW. Once per campaign, your reading extends to the shape of the campaign itself. - MINOR: THE NARROW HOUR. Once per situation, you read one opponent's chart in miniature: the GM tells you the shape of what they intend, and you roll with mastery on your next action against them. - MINOR: THE INSCRIPTION REMAINS. After a reading, you may inscribe the vision. The GM adjusts one aspect of the predicted event in your favour. The stars are not changed; the margins are.

### THE CYCLOPS CANTO

*Ghol-Gan's war-chants were built for throats with more room than yours. Spoken correctly anyway, they still break things.* The canto functions as the following weapon:

(Hunt D6, Spread, Debilitating, One-Shot). It is the sound of a siege happening to the people in front of you. - MINOR: THE BREAKING WORD. The canto gains the Brutal tag. - MINOR: THE WALL-CANTO. Once per situation, instead of attacking, you may speak the building-cantos: rubble, cargo and broken stone heave themselves into a rough rampart, providing cover for you and nearby allies until you move. - MINOR: ONE EYE OPEN. When you speak the canto, you glimpse the field as the cyclops seers did. Allies who act on what you tell them roll their first attack with mastery.

## **THE LIGHT OF DROWNED AZLANT**

*The first empire made light do things light does not do — and not all of it was for seeing by. The sea took them anyway, but it kept their lamps, and some of those lamps were built for war.* Roll Reckon+Ruins to call the cold, searing light of Azlant. It functions as a weapon: (Hunt D8, Ranged) — a lance of impossible brightness that burns where it lands. - MINOR: THE REVEALING BEAM. Instead of burning, spread the light across an area until the end of the situation: it illuminates as full daylight, and within it the invisible, the hidden and the disguised are revealed as what they are. Focus it on a single target and they lose all benefit of concealment, disguise or illusion. - MINOR: LIGHT BELOW. The light works perfectly underwater, and you can send it ahead of you — down a passage, into a wreck, through a hatch — and see what it touches. - MINOR: THE HONEST HOUR. While your light holds, lies discolour the air as they are spoken. You see the stain. So does everyone else.

## **THE ANCESTOR RITES**

*The islands' first peoples did not consider death a reason to stop talking to family.* Roll Reckon+Ruins to cast this spell at any place where people have died. On a success, you call up the dead of that place, and they answer your questions about what they saw, what they knew and what was done to them. They are not compelled to be kind. They are compelled to be honest. - MINOR: DEBTS REMEMBERED. The dead tell you where they left what they valued — the cache, the stash, the buried share. The GM confirms what is still there. - MINOR: THE GRATEFUL DEAD.

Once per session, a spirit you have treated with proper rites does you one small favour in the physical world: a door unbarred, a candle snuffed, a word whispered to a sleeper. - MINOR: THE OLD QUARREL. Once per situation, you may point the dead at the living. The haunting is immediate and terrifying: one adversary treats every action as Risky until they leave the place the dead claim.

## **RUIN SOVEREIGN**

*The things that guard the old places have categories: intruder, prey, and colleague.* Roll Reckon+Ruins when you enter a ruin or wreck to announce yourself in the old forms. On a success, the site's guardians — undead, bound spirits, guardian constructs — treat you as a colleague rather than an intruder unless you give them cause, and the GM gives you warning enough to act when the site's passive hazards would catch you. - MINOR: NAMED BY THE DEAD. The dead in a site know your name and speak to you voluntarily, offering its history and its current occupants without being summoned. - MINOR: CLAIMED SITE. Claim a site as yours — you may hold one at a time. Other factions cannot use it without your permission; attempts encounter inexplicable difficulties that you understand and they do not. - MINOR: THE LIVING RUIN. A site you have claimed begins to respond to you: lights that kindle, passages that open, mechanisms that turn over after centuries of stillness. The GM describes what becomes available.

## **THE SPELL BEYOND MEMORY**

*You recovered it from a tradition so old that no one alive has seen it cast. It does something current magic cannot.* Work with the GM to define your Spell Beyond Memory: unmake a curse permanently without knowing its origin; open a sealed divine space; speak across time to someone now dead; restore a broken thing to its original state. Casting it costs D8 Tide stress and can be done once per session. - MINOR: PRACTISED HAND. Deeper understanding reduces the cost to D4 Tide stress. - MINOR: SHARE THE KNOWLEDGE. You can teach the spell to one other character. Their version is real but unreliable — they roll to cast it. Yours simply

works. - MINOR: THE SECOND RECOVERY. Your research yields a second Spell Beyond Memory, from a different tradition. Define it with the GM.

## **ZENITH ABILITIES**

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### **THE COMPLETE RECORD**

*Not the pirate myths. Not the colonial propaganda. What actually happened.* You have assembled enough to write the true history of the Shackles, from the cyclops empire to the present hour, and you release it. The consequences are seismic: legitimacies collapse, claims dissolve, buried debts surface, and every power in these waters learns what its founding actually looked like. Work out with the GM what breaks and what is set free. You do not get to stand apart from it — the author of that book cannot stay in the Shackles, or cannot stay alive in it, or cannot stay the person who wrote it. Your arc ends in the reverberation.

### **THE ARCHIVIST ETERNAL**

*You carried too much of the record, and the record has opinions about being put down.* You stop ageing. Your memory extends backward past your own birth, into the living history of these waters — every drowning, every founding, every name. A person cannot crew a ship carrying all of that; you take a seat instead. A lighthouse archive, a claimed ruin, a reading room in the back of a Port Peril chart-house: somewhere findable by those who truly need it. You are retired as a player character. Once per campaign, the surviving characters may consult you, and you will give them the truth — the whole of it, which is rarely the same thing as help.

### **THE UNFINISHED WORKING**

*Every drowned tradition died mid-sentence. You have found the end of one.* Once, you perform the final working of a dead civilisation — the one its practitioners were building toward when the sea took them. Define it with the GM, at the scale of the people who attempted it: a drowned city raised for a single day; the Eye quieted for a season; every restless dead of a vanished people settled at once. The working is titanic, and it takes its caster — as it took theirs, which you knew, because you read it,

because that is why the tradition died and the working was never finished until you. The tradition is complete. So is your story.

## CORSAIR

*You have fought on more decks than you can count, in storms and calms, outnumbered and alone. Your body carries the testimony — the scars, the missing pieces, the things that healed wrong. You are not merely a fighter. You are a philosophy of controlled destruction, an argument made in blood and roaring iron that some people simply should not be crossed, and the Shackles has slowly come around to your point of view. Subtlety is for people who cannot afford to be seen coming; you have made yourself expensive to ignore. Every coin you take, you spend — on the crew, on the wake, on the night in port that becomes a story — because gold was never the point. The point is the moment when the grappling hooks bite, the rails come together, and everyone on both decks looks to see where you are standing. The sea made you this way. You have made your peace with it. The sea, as far as anyone can tell, is still deciding.*

## CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Brave
- ◆ DOMAIN: Deepwater
- ◆ RESOURCE: The tooth of something that nearly ate you D6 Deepwater
- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Cutlass Brave D6
  - ◆ Pick one:
    - ◆ Boarding axe Plunder D8, Brutal, Tiring
    - ◆ Brace of pistols Hunt D6, Ranged, Reload
    - ◆ Sea-chest surgeon's kit and belaying pin Tend Blood D6; Brave D6

## CORE ABILITIES

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### THE TESTED BODY

*You have been broken before. You know what it costs to keep moving.* Once per situation, when you suffer Minor Blood fallout, you may ignore its effects until the end of the situation. When the situation ends, the fallout arrives in full and you mark D4 Blood stress — the body keeps honest books.

### VIOLENCE AS ARGUMENT

*Your reputation for controlled, purposeful violence precedes you.* When you make a credible threat of violence to someone who knows your history, roll with mastery to compel, cow or halt them. Once per session, when you publicly demonstrate your capability — breaking something, surviving something, ending a fight with impossible efficiency — clear D4 Reputation stress.

## MINOR ABILITIES

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### BOARDING MASTER

*People don't need your orders. They just move when you move.* Gain the Command skill. When you lead a boarding action, you and all allies following your lead gain +1 Blood protection until they next act.

### EARNED FEAR

*The hesitation your name creates is real, and it buys the time that keeps a legend alive.* Gain +2 Reputation protection.

### FIGHTING TRIM

Gain access to one of the following skills: Brave, Carouse, Command, Endure, Hunt, Navigate, Plunder, Tend, Vanish. You can take this advance more than once.

### HARBOUR LEGEND

*Every dockside from Bloodcove to Drenchport holds someone who saw you fight.* Gain the Port domain. In any port where you have fought before, at least one person will

stand you a drink, back you in a brawl, and tell you what the harbour is saying about you.

## **IRON STOMACH**

*The sea has poisoned you so many ways it has run out of new ones.* Gain the Endure skill. When you mark stress from disease or poison, mark it one dice size smaller.

## **THE KILLING GROUND**

*You move through the aftermath with deliberate efficiency.* Gain the Plunder skill. Once per session, when you loot a battlefield, a boarded ship or a defeated enemy, ask the GM what the most valuable thing present is and they will tell you.

## **NOTCHES ON THE HILT**

*Your weapons are cross-hatched with kill-marks; a testament to what the sea has made of you.* Gain the Hunt skill. Whenever you kill a person or creature, remove 1 stress from any resistance.

## **OLD SALT'S STITCHES**

*You have closed your own wounds in a rolling sea by lamplight — and worse in your crew. It is not gentle work. It holds.* Gain the Tend skill. You can treat your own Blood stress and fallout without assistance and without the Risky penalty. Once per situation, you also patch a nearby ally in the middle of things: remove D6 Blood stress from them, or, with your sea-chest surgeon's kit to hand, downgrade one Minor Blood fallout instead. The crew has learned not to look.

## **RAIDER'S COVES**

*Every coast keeps a place to careen, hide or wait with the guns run out.* Gain the Shallows domain. Once per session, within a day's sail of a coastline, ask the GM for an anchorage suited to hiding, repair or ambush and they will tell you — and whether anyone else knows it.



## SCAR TISSUE

*The sea has tried to kill you in very specific ways. It will have to try differently next time.* Gain +2 Blood protection.

## SEA LEGS

Gain +1 Protection in the Blood, Tide, Reputation or Luck resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

## WHAT'S MINE

*The Code is clear, and so are you.* Gain the Outlaw domain. When someone tries to take what's yours — your ship, your share, your crew — your attacks gain the Brutal tag when you attempt to stop them.

## WHERE THE WIND TAKES YOU

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Port, Colonial, Wilderness. You can take this advance more than once.

## MAJOR ABILITIES

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### THE UNSTOPPABLE

*You are filled with every fight you have ever refused to lose.* When you are suffering from ongoing Blood fallout, increase the stress dice of your attacks by one step. - MINOR: LIMPING ONWARD. THE UNSTOPPABLE also increases the stress dice you inflict on journeys by one step. - MINOR: SCARS LIKE MEDALS. Gain +1 Blood protection while you have ongoing Blood or Reputation fallout; +2 while you have both. - MINOR: ON YOUR FEET. Once per session, downgrade a Major Blood fallout you have to a Minor Blood fallout.

### THE BLACK SPOT

*The Code is older than any navy's law, and you have appointed yourself its instrument.* Once per session, when you find evidence of someone's (or something's) crimes, you can publicly mark them with the black spot. When you or any pirate who

honours the Code tracks down a marked target, roll with mastery. - MINOR: JUDGE. When you track a marked target as part of a journey, increase your stress dice size by 1 step. - MINOR: JURY. You no longer need evidence to mark a target, but you do need a name, a likeness or a first-hand description. - MINOR: EXECUTIONER. When you attack a marked target, increase your stress dice size by 1 step.

## **BOARDING ACTION**

*The rails come together and the chaos organises itself around you.* When you direct a boarding action or ship-to-ship engagement, allies acting under your direction roll with mastery on the first action they take. - MINOR: FIRING SOLUTION. Once per situation, direct cannon fire with precision: one ship takes D8 Hull stress directly, bypassing normal crew actions. - MINOR: NO QUARTER. When the engagement is going your way and the opposing ship attempts to disengage, roll Command+Deepwater to cut off their escape; on a success, they fight or surrender — they cannot simply run. - MINOR: AFTERMATH. After a successful boarding, roll Command+Deepwater to cow the captured crew; on a success, they comply without further violence. They know what the alternative looks like.

## **DECK-FIGHTER**

*Cramped quarters, rolling footing, bodies underfoot — this is your parlour.* When you attack at close range, your attacks gain the Piercing tag, even if you're unarmed. - MINOR: THROUGH THE SMOKE. Gain +2 Blood protection against ranged attacks. - MINOR: FIRST INSULT. The first time you suffer Reputation stress in a situation, do not roll for fallout. One barb never bothers you; it's the accumulation that draws blood. - MINOR: HOMECOMING. When you enter a friendly port after a voyage, refresh stress according to the size and importance of the port — a three-shack anchorage is D4; Port Peril is D12.

## **SHIPSHAPE AND BATTLE-READY**

*Never get into a fight you haven't drilled for.* Once per session, when you have an hour or two in port or at anchor, run preparations for the coming trouble. Pick one benefit; you and everyone who takes part gain it until you next make landfall: - Whetstone

Drill: one weapon gains the Brutal tag. - Rig Check: one piece of Navigate or Tend equipment gains the Trusty tag. - Toughen Up: gain +1 Blood protection. - Steady Hearts: gain +1 Reputation protection. - Stow Smart: gain +1 Gold protection. - MINOR: DOUBLE DUTY. Choose two benefits when using this ability; participants gain both. You can't choose the same benefit twice. - MINOR: MID-WATCH DRILL. You may run preparations during a journey; add a D6 bane to the journey's resistance if you do. - MINOR: EMERGENCY ISSUE. With a few minutes to spare, grant one benefit to yourself or one ally by consuming a resource of D6 or higher value. This doesn't count as the per-session use.

## **ZENITH ABILITIES**

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### **THE LAST STAND**

*Outnumbered, outgunned, cornered — finally, a fair fight.* Once, when retreat is impossible and surrender unthinkable, invoke the Last Stand. For the rest of the situation you cannot be killed, stopped or driven back; every attack you make inflicts maximum stress, and every attack against you inflicts the minimum. When the situation ends — one way or another — the reckoning arrives, and the GM determines what the sea finally claims. It has been waiting a long time, and it is owed.

### **LIVING LEGEND**

*The Shackles has decided you belong to it permanently.* You retire as the unkillable old corsair: the one they name ships for, the one new captains are measured against, the one drinking quietly in the corner whom no one — no one — troubles. Your name becomes a unit of measurement for violence. Work out with the GM where you settle and what it takes to rouse you, because once per campaign, something will be foolish enough to try, and the surviving characters will get to see what the stories were underselling.

### **DOWN WITH THE SHIP**

*To activate this ability, go down with your ship.* The sea takes you both, and the sea keeps what it takes. Your vessel becomes a ghost ship and you its master, sailing the

Shackles forever — glimpsed off storm-heads, becalmed in impossible fog, running before winds that touch nothing else. Once per campaign, when the surviving characters are at sea and beyond hope, your sails appear: one broadside, one rescue, or one escort through water that should kill them. Then you are gone over the horizon, where the dead keep their own watch and the wake never closes.

## DAREDEVIL

*You learned what you know in places that don't appear on any map the respectable world keeps: the travelling circus that wintered in Bloodcove, the knife-throwing act that went wrong in ways you don't discuss, the year with the escapologists and fire-eaters who work the dockside crowds of Port Peril. You are not a planner. You are a mover. Your survival strategy has always been the same: be faster than what's coming, be gone before anyone works out what happened, and if you absolutely must fight, make it spectacular enough that the crowd forgets to stop you leaving. The Shackles is full of people who are very good at standing still and waiting — braced behind gunwales, dug in behind harbour walls, sitting on their reputations like dragons on gold. You have never understood why anyone would do that. Everything you own fits in your pockets, everything you owe is outrun, and every room you have ever entered had at least three ways out. You checked. You always check.*

## CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Vanish
- ◆ DOMAIN: Outlaw
- ◆ RESOURCE: A wanted poster bearing a bad likeness of you D6 Outlaw

- ◆ EQUIPMENT: A knife in your boot Brave D6
- ◆ Pick one:
  - ◆ Matched throwing knives Hunt D6, Ranged, Brutal
  - ◆ Collapsible grapnel and fifty feet of silk line Navigate D6
  - ◆ Pouch of smoke vials Vanish D6

## CORE ABILITIES

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### ALWAYS A WAY OUT

*There are three exits from this room. You checked.* At the start of each situation, declare one exit — a route, a gap, a prepared escape — that exists regardless of circumstances. Once per situation, you may use it to remove yourself (and one ally who stays close) from immediate danger without a roll; when you do, mark D4 stress to Luck — the universe keeps count. This cannot be used if you are bound, submerged or sealed inside something. It can be used if you are outnumbered, surrounded, on fire, or in a conversation that has gone badly.

### MOMENTUM

*As long as you keep moving, the world can't get a grip on you.* When you succeed on any action that involves moving — running, climbing, swinging, diving, vaulting — you may immediately move again as part of the same action without a second roll. On a failure, you still move, but something goes wrong along the way. You cannot benefit from this ability while standing still.

## MINOR ABILITIES

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### ACROBAT

*Your body does things most bodies do not.* Gain the Brave skill. Movement through difficult terrain — rigging, rooftops, crowded docks, collapsing structures — is never considered Risky or Dangerous for you solely because of the physical challenge.

## COASTWISE

*A cove not on any chart; a reef passage that looks like a dead end from the surface.*

Gain the Shallows domain. Roll with mastery to pass through a coastline that is actively searching for you; doing something memorable forfeits the advantage.

## KNIFE ACT

*You were paid to do this without hitting the person standing next to the target.* Gain the Hunt skill. Your thrown blades function as (Hunt D6, Ranged, Brutal) and you carry enough that running out is never the first problem. When you throw at a specific, named point — a held weapon, a rope, a lock, a candle — roll with mastery.

## MISDIRECTION

*People look where you point.* Gain the Deceive skill. Once per situation, direct everyone present to look at something other than what you are actually doing — a shout, a thrown object, a staged stumble. Roll your next action, taken immediately and quietly, with mastery; it cannot be an attack.

## NINE LIVES

*You do not go down easily, and when you do, it is always somewhere inconvenient for whoever put you there.* Gain +2 Blood protection.

## THE PRESTIGE

Gain access to one of the following skills: Brave, Carouse, Command, Deceive, Hunt, Navigate, Plunder, Reckon, Vanish. You can take this advance more than once.

## PICKPOCKET

*A moment of proximity and a moment of distraction.* Gain the Reckon skill. You can lift anything a person is carrying without them noticing; the GM will tell you what they're carrying before you reach for it. If a target is actively watching for theft, roll Vanish — on a partial success you take it, but they notice something was wrong.

## **RIGGING RAT**

*The tops are yours.* Gain the Deepwater domain. You always have the high ground aboard a vessel if you want it, and your first attack after dropping from height gains the Brutal tag.

## **THE ROVING LIFE**

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Port, Colonial, Ruins. You can take this advance more than once.

## **SMOKE AND SHADOW**

*Drinking, laughing, belonging.* Gain the Carouse skill. You can disappear into any crowd by becoming the most natural person in it; roll with mastery to lose a pursuer through a crowd.

## **STREET-LEARNED**

*You watched the colonial system from underneath and learned to abuse it from inside.* Gain the Colonial domain. You know which paperwork holds up, which officials are worth bribing and which laws have convenient loopholes; you can move through colonial-held territory without looking like what you are.

## **TIGHTROPE LUCK**

Gain +1 Protection in the Blood, Tide, Luck or Gold resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

## **THE UNIVERSE KEEPS MISSING**

*Bad luck has to catch you first.* Gain +2 Luck protection.

## **MAJOR ABILITIES**

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### **ALL OR NOTHING**

*You forsake the safe footing for a single, decisive blow.* When you attack an adversary, you can choose to lose your Blood protection for the attack before you roll. If you do so and succeed or partially succeed, add your Blood protection value to the stress

inflicted. - MINOR: INEXORABLE. If the first dice you roll to determine the stress inflicted shows 1 or 2, roll an additional dice of the same size and add the result to the stress inflicted. - MINOR: BLOODIED BUT UNBROKEN. When you have 4 or more stress marked to Blood or are suffering from ongoing Blood fallout, gain +2 Blood protection. - MINOR: SCYTHING BLOW. Once per situation, treat your weapon as though it has the Spread tag when you inflict stress on an adversary.

## **KNIFE STORM**

*More blades than you should reasonably be carrying.* Once per situation, gain access to the following weapon: (Hunt D6, Ranged, Spread). Where the knives came from is a question no one gets a satisfying answer to. - MINOR: SPECIALTY LOAD. Some of the knives are alchemical. Choose one effect when you use KNIFE STORM: affected targets catch fire (D4 stress per round until extinguished), are drowsy (their next action is Risky), or are poisoned (the knives gain the Degenerating tag). - MINOR: PINNED. Targets harmed by KNIFE STORM are pinned to whatever surface is behind them, restrained until they work free — which takes a full action. - MINOR: ENCORE. KNIFE STORM can be used twice per situation. The crowd demands it.

## **THE IMPOSSIBLE ROUTE**

*Across the burning deck, up the outside of the moving ship, through the crowd of armed opponents.* Once per situation, declare a path through an environment that should not exist and roll with mastery to take it; on a failure you still arrive, but something goes wrong along the way. The GM describes what it looks like from the outside. Anyone attempting to follow must roll at one difficulty step higher than normal. - MINOR: TAKE SOMEONE WITH YOU. One ally can follow THE IMPOSSIBLE ROUTE without rolling. They must stay right behind you and do exactly what you do. - MINOR: CANNONBALL. Once per session, a ship's cannon, catapult or comparable device counts as the start of an Impossible Route. You survive the launch. You land where you aimed, roughly. The enemy never expects this. - MINOR: THE IMPOSSIBLE RETURN. Once per session, THE IMPOSSIBLE



ROUTE works in reverse: re-enter a location you escaped by the same path, arriving exactly where you want to be.

## THE READ

*This is not magic. It is the pattern recognition of someone who has survived a great many rooms.* Roll Reckon+Outlaw after observing an environment or an ongoing fight for a few moments. On a success, the GM tells you how the next minute is likely to unfold — who moves where, what breaks, which route opens, which opponent overcommits — and you roll with mastery when acting on what you learned. - MINOR: THE OPENING. THE READ always identifies one moment of opening; an attack made in that moment increases its stress dice by one step. - MINOR: THE COUNTER. When an enemy attempts a prepared ambush or tactical surprise against you, invoke THE READ to reverse it: you anticipated this, and they are the ones who walked into something. - MINOR: THE AUDIENCE. Describe THE READ aloud to your allies: they roll with mastery on their first action taken on what you saw.

## THE VANISHING ACT

*You simply are not there anymore.* Once per session, roll Vanish+Outlaw to disappear completely — mid-conversation, mid-combat, mid-arrest. On a success you are simply gone, reappearing at the start of the next situation somewhere that makes sense, carrying everything you had. On a partial success you are gone, but you leave something behind — the GM chooses what. - MINOR: TAKE THE EVIDENCE. When you use THE VANISHING ACT, take one object from the area with you. It vanishes when you do. - MINOR: LEAVE A DOUBLE. Something remains in your place briefly — a coat, a hat, a silhouette that is not quite right. It buys a few precious seconds — until someone acts on it — before anyone realises you are gone. - MINOR: CROWD WORK. THE VANISHING ACT can remove one ally alongside you. They must be touching you when you go.

## ZENITH ABILITIES

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### THE GRAND EXIT

*Not run. Leave.* Once, at a moment of your choosing, you make the most spectacular, inexplicable, impossible departure the Shackles has ever witnessed — the burning ship walked off, the blockade sailed through laughing, the prison no one saw you leave. You go where you choose, intact and free of every consequence that was chasing you, and the story is told in ports for years. Your character leaves the game the way they always intended to leave everything: perfectly, and on their own terms.

### UNKILLABLE

*Cheating death has become a professional credential.* Ordinary violence, misfortune and circumstance can no longer end you — a rope frays, a pistol misfires, a jailer falls asleep, every single time. Play out the current situation untouchable, and then the character passes out of play and into legend: sighted everywhere, confirmed nowhere, reported dead at least annually and never accurately. The Shackles stops asking whether the stories are true, because the answer has stopped mattering. That might be what you were performing for all along. It might not be the same thing as freedom.

### THE LAST TRICK

*To activate this ability, die — saving someone, mid-stunt, in front of witnesses.* The death is so audacious, so impossible, so perfectly timed that everyone who sees it is changed by it. All nearby allies remove all ongoing fallout and all stress marked to all resistances, and roll with mastery for the remainder of the situation: the crowd you played to your whole life finally moves the way you always moved. No body is ever recovered. No one who saw it can quite believe you're gone. Perhaps you aren't.

## ERRANT

*You came from somewhere with rules. Not the Pirate Code — that is a contract between people who distrust each other, enforced by the threat of violence. You came*

*from somewhere with forms: the bow before the engagement, the offered hilt, the understanding that violence conducted correctly is something distinct from violence conducted badly, and that the distinction matters. Maybe you were Chelish nobility before a political miscalculation. Maybe you trained in the duelling academies of Absalom, or swore vows to an order that no longer answers your letters, before whatever happened happened and the Shackles became the only place that would have you. You carry the form the way some people carry a language — not as an affectation, but as the structure through which you perceive things. When you look at a fight you see lines, angles and the grammar of engagement your tradition mapped out centuries before you were born. The pirates of the Shackles are dangerous, many of them, in ways that are real and serious. None of them were trained. None of them have a lineage. None of them spent ten years in a school learning to fight a problem before it arrived. This is not arrogance. It is simply a fact about what formal training does — and the Shackles is currently in the process of learning it.*

## CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Hunt
- ◆ DOMAIN: Colonial
- ◆ RESOURCE: A signet ring of a house that no longer claims you D6 Colonial
- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Pick one:
  - ◆ Heirloom duelling sword Hunt D8, Piercing, Expensive
  - ◆ Matched pistol and parrying blade Hunt D6, Ranged, Reload; Hunt D6, Brutal
  - ◆ Campaign kit: field manuals, whetstone and surgeon's roll Tend Blood D6; arming sword Brave D6

## CORE ABILITIES

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### THE FORM

*You trained in a specific, named fighting tradition — establish it at character creation: its place of origin, its philosophy, its lineage of masters. When you fight a*

single opponent in conditions that allow the form to operate — space to move, clear engagement lines, some degree of mutual awareness — the stress dice of your attacks increases by one step. When the Shackles refuses to hold still and be a proper fight, you still know more than they do. You are just doing it the hard way.

## **READ THE FIGHTER**

*Training creates patterns, and patterns can be known.* Once per session, after watching someone fight, spar or simply move, the GM tells you their strongest technique and their worst vulnerability. Roll with mastery when you act on what you learned. This works on anyone with something resembling technique; those who fight with pure chaos or supernatural force cannot be read this way.

## **MINOR ABILITIES**

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### **ACADEMY TRAINING**

Gain access to one of the following skills: Brave, Carouse, Command, Deceive, Endure, Hunt, Reckon, Tend, Vanish. You can take this advance more than once.

### **CAMPAIGN HARDENED**

Gain +1 Protection in the Blood, Reputation, Luck or Gold resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

### **CHALLENGE**

*The terms you set are binding.* Gain the Command skill. Once per session, issue a formal challenge that carries legal and social weight in any port with colonial influence — which in the Inner Sea means most of them. The target must respond publicly: accept, refuse and lose standing, or attempt to avoid, which you may pursue without social consequence.

### **THE CODE DUELLO**

*Two legal systems govern formal violence in these waters. You know how to invoke both, and how to make them conflict when that is useful.* Gain the Outlaw domain. The

Pirate Code's provisions for challenges, duels and trials by combat are as familiar to you as your own school's forms, and most Free Captains will pause and hear you out when you cite them.

## **COLONIAL PASSAGE**

*Your bearing, your vocabulary and a name you can support open doors that are closed to pirates.* Gain the Deceive skill. Roll with mastery when you pass as a naval officer, merchant official or member of a noble house.

## **FORM PERFECT**

*Combat in the Shackles is audience as much as violence.* Gain the Port domain. When fighting where others can observe you, roll with mastery on your first action — and afterwards, you know exactly how the story will be told in the taverns tomorrow, and to whom.

## **LETTERS OF CREDIT**

*Your name is still good with colonial banking houses that have not yet heard, or do not care, what you have become.* Gain +2 Gold protection.

## **MEASURED THREAT**

*The colonial world produced a specific kind of person who can make death sound like a scheduling matter.* Gain the Endure skill. When you indicate with cold technical precision that a situation is about to become violent, NPCs of reasonable intelligence believe it without demonstration.

## **NAVAL LAW**

*Prize law, letters of marque, and the provisions that distinguish piracy from privateering.* Gain the Reckon skill. Once per session, ask the GM what legal mechanism — a technicality, a jurisdictional gap, a formal right — applies to the current situation that no one else present knows exists. The GM answers honestly, and the mechanism is real.

## SCHOOLED DEFENCE

*Your tradition spent centuries working out how to survive being wrong once. Gain +2 Blood protection.*

## SECOND STEEL

*A tradition that does not account for the loss of the primary weapon is not a complete tradition. Yours is complete. Gain the Brave skill. You fight equally well with either hand, and when disarmed, you produce a second weapon without a roll — it was always there.*

## SWORN ORDER

*The vows are older than the exile. Gain the Faith domain. Once per session, when you keep your vows at real cost to yourself — protecting someone inconvenient, honouring terms no one would have enforced — clear D4 Reputation stress. Word of it travels.*

## A WIDER EDUCATION

*Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Colonial, Port, Faith. You can take this advance more than once.*

## MAJOR ABILITIES

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### DUELLIST'S GAZE

*Some people only need to be looked at correctly. Your gaze functions as a weapon (Hunt D6, Ranged). It only works when your target can see you and has the capacity to be afraid of you — so fighters, captains and officials are fair game, but sea monsters aren't. You can use this "weapon" in a port or aboard ship without causing a huge ruckus. Your gaze won't kill: if you reduce an opponent's resistance to 0 with it, they yield, bargain or withdraw with whatever dignity remains to them. - MINOR: LEGENDARY. Your gaze now works on things that shouldn't be scared of you. - MINOR: AT THE SALUTE. Your gaze gains the Point-Blank tag. - MINOR: NO*

SYMPATHY. Once per situation, your gaze functions as (Tend Blood D6, Ranged) as you give your allies a disapproving glance that spurs them into action.

## THE ORDER'S BLADE

*You have been entrusted with a greatblade from your order's vaults — an ancient weapon designed for the things that colonial fleets pretend not to lose ships to.* A greatblade has two profiles: one when used against human-sized targets (Hunt D6, Tiring), and one when used against targets significantly larger than yourself (Hunt D10, Tiring). - MINOR: HUNTED. Name the creature that is coming after you. Once per session, you can declare that it replaces the opposition in a dangerous scene as it eats them, chases them off or causes a big distraction — the GM decides. You'll have to fight or evade it yourself now, of course. If you kill it, gain a minor advance and remove this ability. - MINOR: ENDURANCE TRAINING. Your greatblade no longer has the Tiring tag, and inflicts D8 stress against human-sized targets. - MINOR: APPLIED RESEARCH. Once per situation, when you inflict stress on an adversary, you can identify its weak spots. For the remainder of the situation, you treat that adversary's difficulty as one step lower (to a minimum of Standard) when acting against it.

## THE COMMITTED BLADE

*The form demands commitment: the difference between a duel and a gamble is the quality of your training.* When you succeed at a Risky action, increase the size of the stress dice you inflict by 1 step. When you succeed at a Dangerous action, increase the size of the stress dice you inflict by 2 steps. You can choose to make an action Risky or Dangerous, even if it's Standard, to gain access to this benefit. - MINOR: IMPLACABLE FORM. When you take stress due to attempting a Risky or Dangerous action, the stress dice is reduced by 1 step. - MINOR: THE PERFECT EXCHANGE. Once per session, when you succeed at a Risky or Dangerous action, clear all stress marked against your resistances. - MINOR: THE OFFERED HILT. Once per situation, you may grant the benefits of THE COMMITTED BLADE to a nearby ally.

## THE PROTECTOR'S STANCE

*You did not cross half the world to watch the people beside you die badly.* Any ally within arm's reach of you gains +1 Blood protection thanks to your interventions. Once per situation, you can bark a correction — footwork, guard, distance — and remove D4 Blood stress from a nearby ally. - MINOR: LAST-MINUTE INTERVENTION. Once per session, when an ally within arm's reach of you suffers Blood fallout, immediately downgrade it by one step (or remove it entirely if it's Minor fallout). - MINOR: BACK-TO-BACK. If there's only one ally within arm's reach of you, they gain +2 Blood protection instead of +1. - MINOR: THE BORROWED PARRY. Once per session, when an ally within arm's reach would mark Blood stress from a melee attack, the stress dice is reduced to D4. You were already there. You do not explain how.

## THE REPUTATION OF THE BLADE

*Your record — challenges accepted and resolved, the names of those you have fought, the tradition you represent — travels ahead of you.* In colonial-influenced territory, fighters who know your reputation find reasons to delay rather than engage you in single combat, unless something larger than fear compels them. Additionally, once per session, your name opens a door: a colonial official who will hear you out, a naval officer who stands down rather than escalate, a port that waves you through. - MINOR: THE INEVITABLE RESULT. NPCs aware of your full record do not challenge you to a fight they believe they will lose. They find other methods — which is often worse for everyone, and frequently more interesting. - MINOR: THE YOUNG ONES COME. Rising fighters seek you out to prove themselves against a named opponent. Every so often — the GM decides when — one arrives who is genuinely trained. Whether you defeat them, teach them, recruit them or send them away changed is yours to determine. - MINOR: COLONIAL WEIGHT. Once per session, in formal dealings with a colonial power, invoke your name and lineage to achieve an outcome that would require significant political capital from anyone without a formal fighting pedigree.



## ZENITH ABILITIES

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### THE LAST BOUT

*The argument reaches its final form.* You face the opponent who represents the ultimate test of what you and your tradition have been building toward — the one person, institution or force whose defeat, or whose defeat of you, answers the question your arc has been asking. Win or lose, the exchange is perfect in form, and it removes you from the story: dead, or finished in the way that means there is nothing left to prove and no reason to stay. The Shackles will remember it one way. The colonial world will remember it another. Both will be partially right.

### THE HOMECOMING

*You return to the place that exiled you, and conclude the argument with the institution itself.* Once, your challenge binds an entire colonial power — the house that disowned you, the academy that struck your name, the court that signed the warrant. They must answer it: their champion against you, everything staked, under forms so old that refusing them would unmake the institution's authority in front of everyone it rules. The outcome reshapes that institution permanently — work out with the GM what falls, what changes and what is restored. Win or lose, you do not return to the Shackles. The argument is over, and you were always going to finish it at home.

### THE SCHOOL FOUNDED

*The tradition was carried across an ocean to arrive at this.* You formalise everything — the old form, and everything the Shackles taught you about what it was missing — into a living school: named, located, with students and a documented lineage that now ends in you. You retire as its master. For the remainder of the campaign, the school functions as a landmark and a faction: its students recognisable by form and footwork, its hall a place where formal challenge is sacrosanct, its doors open to the surviving player characters whenever they need shelter, instruction or a second who will not run. One day, long after you are gone, the colonial world will send its children here to train. You will not live to see it. You founded it anyway.

## POWDER MAGE

*Magic and gunpowder have one thing in common: they both kill you if you handle them carelessly. You have learned to handle both carefully enough that it is everyone else who dies. You channel arcane force through iron and smoke, stitching spellwork into the moment of firing, turning a pistol shot into something that defies physics and good sense. In the colonial navies they would have burned you for it; in the Shackles they just want to know what it costs to hire you. The answer is more than they think, because the real price is not paid in gold. The magic is eating through you — slowly, inexorably, a grain at a time, the way a slow match eats cord. You have decided the price is worth it. The power is undeniable; addictive, in fact. To hold the moment of detonation in your mind, to feel every charge and loaded barrel within thirty paces like sparks behind your eyes — there is nothing else like it, and safety, solvency and your own flesh have all become secondary to the next impossible shot.*

### CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Hunt
- ◆ DOMAIN: Arcane
- ◆ RESOURCE: A horn of powder cut with ground witch-salts D6 Arcane
- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Pick one:
  - ◆ Two old-fashioned pistols Hunt D8, Ranged, Loud, One-Shot
  - ◆ Witch-etched duelling pistol Hunt D6, Ranged, Brutal, Dangerous
  - ◆ Overstuffed coat of tools and charms and a boot-pistol Tend Blood D6; Hunt D6, Ranged, Reload

### CORE ABILITIES

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#### POWDER BOND

*The tingle in your fingers tells you where the fire is.* You can detonate any unattended powder charge or loaded firearm within thirty paces by will alone; powder carried or

worn by a person is shielded by its bearer's luck — detonating it is an attack, rolled Hunt+Arcane. You always know the location of gunpowder, loaded weapons and other ignition sources nearby — including magical equivalents: fire-workings, alchemical bombs, anything waiting to burn.

## **BURN THE BODY**

*The magic is eating through you, and you have learned to lean into the heat.* When your Blood stress is 4 or higher, roll with mastery when you attempt to cast a spell.

## **MINOR ABILITIES**

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### **BEEN EVERYWHERE**

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Arcane, Colonial, Faith, Ruins. You can take this advance more than once.

### **BY ANY MEANS**

Gain access to one of the following skills: Brave, Carouse, Deceive, Hunt, Navigate, Plunder, Reckon, Tend, Vanish. You can take this advance more than once.

### **CALLED SHOT**

*Wind, distance, angle, the target's movement — the answer arrives complete.* Gain the Reckon skill. When you name a specific point before firing — a hand, a rope, a lock, a lantern — and succeed, the shot hits exactly that point. This is not magic. It is calculation.

### **DEEP POCKETS**

*Your coat is overstuffed with the trade's leavings: doctored powder, fuse-cord, charms against damp, and three things you could sell if it came to that.* Gain +2 Gold protection.

## **FALSE THUNDER**

*Besmara's thunder and yours are indistinguishable from the deck of a sinking ship.*

Gain the Faith domain. When you use SLOW MATCH, you may also consume resources with the Faith domain.

## **GHOL-GAN FIRE**

*You have recovered pre-human incendiary formulae from drowned stonework, and improved them.* Gain the Ruins domain. Choose one alchemical round you know how to brew: incendiary (the target catches fire, marking D4 stress each round until extinguished), concussive (the target's next action is Risky) or smoking (the area gains the Obscuring quality). You can carry three at a time; restocking takes an hour of downtime.

## **NAVY GUNNER**

*You learned the great guns on a colonial deck before the magic found you.* Gain the Colonial domain. You can crew, aim and command cannon of any navy's pattern, and you know their drill, their signals and the layout of their magazines from the inside.

## **QUICK DRAW**

*They didn't catch you without a weapon. They simply didn't find the one you had.* Gain the Brave skill. Regardless of searches, disarmament or social convention, you always have something small, loaded and sufficient.

## **SIPHON OF FORTUNE**

*There are tables in Port Peril where you can stake more than coin; your wager of choice is good luck.* Gain +2 Luck protection.

## **SLOW MATCH**

*Powder burned with intention is a prayer the universe has to answer.* Gain the Tend skill. Before you cast a spell from this class, you can opt to destroy a resource with the Arcane domain. Roll the resource's dice; the amount rolled is added to your Protection value against any stress incurred as a result of casting the spell.

## **SMOKE AND MIRRORS**

*The smoke goes where you tell it.* Gain the Vanish skill. When you fire, you can direct the smoke to obscure vision, and you may roll Vanish with mastery to reposition unseen behind it.

## **THE POWDER TRADE**

*Your appetite put you deep into the networks that move powder through the Shackles.* Gain the Outlaw domain. Once per session, ask the GM where powder can be sourced in this port, regardless of legality, and they will tell you; the smugglers who move it consider you a customer worth keeping alive.

## **WARDING SPELLS**

Gain +1 Protection in the Blood, Tide, Luck or Gold resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

## **MAJOR ABILITIES**

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### **ARCANE LOAD**

*You stitch the working into the charge itself, and the shot carries it.* Roll Hunt+Arcane to lay a working into a loaded weapon; this takes a few minutes, and a weapon holds one working at a time. When the weapon is fired, the shot is Seeking: it bends toward its target, ignoring cover and intervening obstacles. - MINOR: SHATTERING LOAD. When you lay a working, you may choose this instead: on a hit, the target's Blood protection is reduced by 2 until the end of the situation. - MINOR: OVERCHARGE. When you lay a working, you may choose this instead: the shot's stress dice increases by two steps, and you mark D4 Blood stress when it is fired. - MINOR: TWO BARRELS. You may have two laden weapons at once, and you may lay workings into an ally's weapon as easily as your own.

### **POWDER KEG**

*Everything within thirty paces is a bomb if you are standing near it.* Once per session, you may detonate a powder magazine, a cannon battery or a large alchemical store.

The explosion inflicts D10 Blood stress on everyone in the area and Hull stress on any vessel present, destroys the source entirely, and renders the area uninhabitable for the rest of the situation. You mark D6 Blood stress from the expenditure. - MINOR: CONTROLLED BURN. Designate one person or object in the blast radius that takes no stress from the detonation. Everything else still burns. - MINOR: DISTANCE DETONATION. You can trigger POWDER KEG from anywhere, provided you have sensed the powder with POWDER BOND. You do not need to be nearby. You do not need to watch. - MINOR: CHAIN DETONATION. Every powder charge and loaded weapon within the blast radius detonates as well, potentially expanding the zone. The GM determines the cascade.

## **SPARK IN THE CHAMBER**

*You snap your fingers and the air inside them remembers it wanted to be fire.* This spell functions as the following weapon: (Hunt D6, Piercing.) If the target is carrying powder or a loaded firearm, it inflicts D8 stress. - MINOR: THE SLOW BURN. Targets you harm with SPARK IN THE CHAMBER catch fire, marking D4 stress each round until extinguished. - MINOR: SMOKELESS. The spark leaves no flash, no smoke and no evident cause. Unless someone knows what a powder mage is and that one is present, the death reads as a terrible accident. - MINOR: COIN-GOLD BLOOD. You gain Protection 5 against stress marked due to flame or heat.

## **VEIL OF SMOKE**

*A battlefield is a text written in smoke, and you hold the pen.* Roll Vanish+Arcane to cast this spell. On a success, powder smoke floods an area roughly the size of a ship's deck and obeys you: all Vanish checks within it are made with mastery, and ranged attacks into or through it are Risky. The veil lasts until the end of the situation, or until you leave it. - MINOR: CHOKING CLOUD. Adversaries inside the veil who need to breathe treat every action as Risky until they leave it. - MINOR: SHAPES IN THE SMOKE. The smoke shows your enemies things that are not there. While the veil holds, the GM treats your allies' numbers and positions as unknown to adversaries, even ones who watched them enter. - MINOR: THE SIGNAL FIRE. A fire you kindle

can be seen clearly for twenty miles, in any weather. What it says, and to whom, is up to you.

## THE HIDDEN MAGAZINE

*Every coast in the Shackles holds a dry cache someone died before emptying. You can smell them.* Roll Reckon+Arcane to cast this spell. On a success, you find (or spontaneously discover) a path to a hidden powder store nearby — a smuggler's cache, a wrecked warship's intact hold, a battery abandoned with its magazine sealed. When you work there, remove D6 stress from Blood; your allies may use it the same way. The path seals after an hour or so — with warning, so you'll have time to leave. - MINOR: BENEVOLENT. You or any ally may remove D6 stress from Luck or Gold instead. - MINOR: OMNIPRESENT. You access the same magazine every time, no matter where you are. At the GM's discretion, Major Luck fallout could see it found and emptied by someone else. - MINOR: BOUNTIFUL. Once per session, when you access the magazine, you can locate a non-unique item of D8 value or lower.

## ZENITH ABILITIES

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### THE FINAL CHARGE

*Every grain of arcane force your body has stored, released at once.* Once, you can let it all go. The detonation is apocalyptic at scale — a fortress, a fleet, a harbour. Everything within a wide radius takes maximum stress; what the GM rules destroyed is destroyed. You survive, barely, but your body will never hold arcane force again: every ability of this class burns out of you with the blast. You live. You are no longer a powder mage. Whether it was worth it is the question your arc was always asking.

### THE PERFECT SHOT

*The universe finally agrees that you are right.* Once, at a moment of your choosing, you make a shot of impossible precision — through a fortress wall, across an ocean, backward into an old wound that never closed. It lands, and the target suffers its full consequence. There are no conditions and no defence. But the universe's agreement is purchased, not given, and the price is the one you have been paying all along,

compounded: the recoil takes everything that is left of you. The shot is the last thing you do, and the best.

## THE UNDYING SPARK

*You stop carrying the fire and become it. At the heart of a great burning — a magazine, a fireship, a battery in full roar — you let the boundary go. Your body is unmade, and what you were disperses into every charge of powder in the Shackles. From now on, when desperate gunners pray over a wet charge that fires anyway, when a pistol misfires in the hand of a murderer at exactly the right moment, when a powder mage yet unborn feels the first tingle behind their eyes — that is you, or what you have become. The GM determines when and how the spark shows itself. It never speaks. It always burns.*

## SAWBONE

*The saw that opens a chest cavity and the saw that cuts a rotten plank are the same saw. The pins that hold a shattered femur together and the pins that splice a split timber are the same gauge. You worked out early that a ship's carpenter and a ship's surgeon are doing the same job — assess the damage, remove what cannot be saved, reinforce what can, return the patient to function — and the Shackles has spent your whole career confirming it. You have taken off arms below decks during a broadside and crawled into the bilge to patch shot-holes in the same afternoon, and the problems felt identical. The others aboard traffic in pacts and omens and reputations; you traffic in copper, tar, catgut and lead. When the witch's familiar dies, when the god goes quiet, when the luck runs out — they bring it to you, because you are the only one aboard whose power does not have an opinion. And underneath the daily work there is the project: the thing you are building that the Shackles says is impossible. The hand that closes when the forearm flexes. The pump no flooding can outrun. The heart that beats without flesh to drive it. It will take years. It may not work. You are going to build it anyway.*



## CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Tend
- ◆ DOMAIN: Deepwater
- ◆ RESOURCE: A jar of copper pins and good tar D6 Deepwater
- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Bone saw Brave D6
  - ◆ Pick one:
    - ◆ Carpenter's maul Brave D8, Brutal, Tiring
    - ◆ Surgeon's field roll Tend Blood D6
    - ◆ Tar, canvas and copper patching kit Tend Hull D6

## CORE ABILITIES

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### THE SAME SAW

*The ship is a body. The body is a ship. Both can be fixed.* Your Tend rolls apply equally to flesh and timber — you never choose a specialism. Once per situation, when you spend a minute examining a person or a vessel, the GM tells you what is broken, how badly, and what it would take to fix it.

### THE GRAND PROJECT

*It will take years. It may not be possible. You are building it anyway.* At character creation, define your grand project: a piece of engineering or surgery beyond what the Shackles believes possible — a thinking prosthetic, an unsinkable hull, a mechanical organ. Work with the GM to establish three milestones: discoveries to be made, materials to be sourced, techniques to be proven in play. Milestones are priced like major story beats — each costs a journey's worth of play, a rare material, or a real concession. When the project is complete, it works. Exactly as designed.

## MINOR ABILITIES

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### AMPUTATION

*This is not a last resort. Sometimes it is the most efficient solution.* Gain the Brave skill. Once per session, when a limb or extremity is the site of Blood fallout, you can remove it cleanly in one action: downgrade Major Blood fallout to Minor, or remove a Minor fallout entirely. The limb is gone. You carry everything you need to do this at any time.

### THE SAW CUTS BOTH WAYS

*Flesh comes apart the way timber does — along lines you have spent a career learning to read. Taking a thing apart is the same knowledge as putting it back together, run backwards and without the care.* Gain the Brave skill. Your trade tools — bone saw, maul, pick, mallet — are proper weapons in your hands, with no improvised penalty. Once per situation, when you attack a living target at close range, your strike finds an anatomical weak point and gains the Piercing tag.

### BONESETTER

*Most surgeons would not call it medicine. Most surgeons lose more patients.* Gain the Wilderness domain. You can treat wounds, infections and tropical disease with what grows or washes up anywhere in the Shackles; when treating Blood fallout with improvised materials in the field, your Tend dice increases by one step.

### THE CARPENTER'S EYE

*Everything built is a diagram of how it fails.* Gain the Plunder skill. You can always tell where a structure's load-bearing points are, and you roll with mastery when stripping, shoring up or bringing down any structure — ship, fort, dock, ruin.

### JOURNEYMAN'S PAPERS

Gain access to one of the following skills: Brave, Carouse, Command, Deceive, Endure, Navigate, Plunder, Reckon, Tend. You can take this advance more than once.

## THE INDISPENSABLE

*Touch the cook and the crew grumbles. Touch the sawbones and the crew mutinies.*

Gain +2 Reputation protection.

## SALVAGE INSTINCT

*You know what the wreck is worth before the water settles.* Gain the Port domain.

Once per session, when you encounter a wreck or damaged vessel, ask the GM what it is worth and who will pay for it, and they will tell you.

## SHIPS' GRAVEYARDS

*Low tide is a market and you have the only key.* Gain the Shallows domain. When careening or repairing a beached vessel, the work takes half the usual time.

## STEADY HANDS

*The deck heels, the guns roar, the lantern gutters. The stitch goes where you put it.*

Gain the Endure skill. Work done with your hands is never considered Risky or Dangerous for you solely because of conditions — ship movement, battle, darkness, exhaustion.

## TOOLS OF THE TRADE

*Your kit is your capital, and your skills convert to coin in any port in the world.* Gain +2 Gold protection.

## WHERE THE WORK IS

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Port, Colonial, Ruins. You can take this advance more than once.

## WORKED HANDS

Gain +1 Protection in the Blood, Reputation, Luck or Gold resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

## YARD-TRAINED

*You apprenticed where the standards were written down. Gain the Colonial domain. You know the navies' yards, stores, surgeries and paperwork from the inside, and your work passes their inspections — which opens doors a pirate's work should not.*

## MAJOR ABILITIES

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### CANNIBALISED PARTS

*Everything is parts, if you're honest about it — and parts can mend a hull, arm a trap, or come apart in someone's hands.* Once per session, consume a resource with the Port or Colonial domain by stripping it for materials. Roll the resource's dice and choose one: - Inflict stress on a journey or an adversary equal to the amount rolled, as you jury-rig exactly the wrong surprise for them. - Remove stress from a vessel's Hull equal to the amount rolled. - (D8 or higher) Gain access to a skill or domain for the rest of the session — the manual was in the crate. - (D8 or higher) Increase your Blood protection by 1 for the rest of the situation — armour the work. - Remove stress from a person's Blood equal to the amount rolled. - MINOR: ANYTHING'S PARTS. Resources with any domain qualify. A relic is brass and leverage; a holy text is paper and binding wire. - MINOR: THE GOOD STUFF. When you consume a resource of D8 or higher value, choose two benefits instead of one. - MINOR: TWICE OVER. You may use CANNIBALISED PARTS twice per session. The second time, mark D4 Luck stress — somewhere, something you stripped is missed.

### THE LIVING SHIP

*You have mapped every weakness, tracked every repair, predicted every failure. The ship does not surprise you.* Once per session, the GM warns you of a threat to your vessel before it lands — the shot that will find the magazine, the reef that will open the hull, the plank that gives in the next storm. While you are aboard, your vessel counts as having +1 Hull protection. - MINOR: REPAIR IN MOTION. Once per situation, clear D4 Hull stress without it costing you your action. You were already down there. - MINOR: THE SOUL PERSISTS. If your ship is lost, salvage one

essential piece of her from the wreckage. The next vessel you fit it to becomes your ship immediately — you know her weaknesses as if you'd served aboard a year. - MINOR: NO DEAD SHIPS. When weather, flooding or reef damage alone would sink a vessel you actively maintain, roll Tend+Deepwater; on a success, you find the solution just in time.

## **ENGINEERING MIND**

*If it could exist, you can build it.* Roll Tend+Deepwater to improve a piece of equipment with moving parts using work that takes around half an hour. On a success, increase the equipment's quality by 1 step (standard becomes good, good becomes excellent) and give it the Dangerous and Unreliable tags; once you have improved a piece of equipment this way, you can't improve it again. Given time and materials set by the GM, you can also design and build devices the Shackles has never seen — pumps, fire-weapons, mechanical locks, prosthetics that restore full function. - MINOR: RAPID BUILD. A week's construction takes a day; a day's takes an hour. Your hands know the answer before your mind finishes articulating it. - MINOR: BREAKING POINT. You read where a thing fails — enemy ship, fortification, machine or human body — and exploit it. Roll with mastery to identify the weak point: against a structure or vessel your sabotage can be made to look like an accident; against a living target, your next attack reduces their Blood protection by 2 until the end of the situation, or finds the gap and gains the Piercing tag. - MINOR: THE PERFECT INSTRUMENT. Build items of exceptional quality: one additional tag of your choice, and it cannot break under normal use. You can maintain one such instrument at a time.

## **THE MILESTONE**

*Progress is progress, whatever the context.* You complete one milestone of your grand project. Work out with the GM what was proven, sourced or built, and gain an immediate, concrete mechanical benefit related to the project's nature — a working prototype element, a tested technique, a processed material. Each subsequent major advance you take may represent a further milestone if you choose. - MINOR: WIDER

APPLICATION. The milestone's benefit applies in one additional context beyond its obvious use. The prosthetic technique repairs rigging; the pump design drains a wound. The overlap was always there once you saw it. - MINOR: THE PROTOTYPE. Build a functional prototype from the milestone. It works at reduced capacity — but it works now, in the field, before the project is done. The GM sets its profile. - MINOR: COLLABORATOR. One character who has worked alongside you gains a benefit from the milestone as well — less refined than yours, but functional. The knowledge has transferred.

## NOT TODAY

*You are not performing a miracle. You are refusing the outcome, and you have the competence to make the refusal stick.* Once per campaign, save a ship or a person that should be lost: a vessel taking its killing blow stays functional for one more situation; a patient who should be dead is not. The bill for the materials, the labour and the nerve arrives later — when it lands, mark D6 stress to two different resistances of the GM's choice, and you pay it without comment. - MINOR: THE IMPOSSIBLE REPAIR. Once per session, clear D8 Hull stress from your vessel. You were working on it the whole time; you simply didn't mention it. - MINOR: THE IMPOSSIBLE SURGERY. Once per session, spend the situation operating: remove all Blood stress from one character and clear one of their Minor Blood fallouts. They are functional when it ends. Comfortable was never the service offered. - MINOR: RESURRECTION. Restore a destroyed ship, or a character who has suffered Critical Blood fallout but not yet been written out of the story, to full function. This takes months of in-fiction work, significant materials and problems worth playing through. What the patient remembers is between them and the GM.

## ZENITH ABILITIES

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### THE PROJECT COMPLETE

*It works. Exactly as you designed it.* The grand project is finished: the hand that answers thought, the hull that will not drown, the heart that beats without flesh. Work with the GM to determine its full expression and what it does to the world — because

things that work this well change the Shackles, and they attract everything that profits from change. Your character's story ends alongside the project's beginning: retire as the one who built the impossible thing, or be swallowed by the consequences of its existence. Either way, the Shackles now contains something it cannot un-know, and your name is on it.

## THE SHIP ETERNAL

*To activate this ability, give yourself to the work completely.* One vessel — yours, or one you choose to save — becomes unsinkable, forever. You go into her the way everything you have goes into the work: your knowledge, your attention, and finally yourself. No body is recovered; there was no death anyone witnessed; there is simply a ship on which the pumps start themselves, fires gutter out before they catch, and sprung planks close overnight like wounds. She cannot be lost for the remainder of the campaign. Her crews swear the tools in the carpenter's walk are always warm, and that something below decks hums when the work is done right.

## EVERY PATIENT LIVES

*To activate this ability, work yourself to death.* Once, when the dying outnumber the living — a battle's aftermath, a plague port, a fleet broken on a reef — you refuse all of it. You work through the night, the next day, the next night, performing surgery and salvage beyond what hands should manage, and at the end of it every patient brought to you survives: all nearby allies and every named character present recover all Blood stress and all Blood fallout. You do not. The Shackles' surgeons still argue about that night, and teach it. Every crew in these waters knows the toast: the sawbones pays the bill.

## SHARPER

*Every Free Captain thinks they understand the game — raids, plunder, loyalty, fear. You understand the game that happens underneath that game. Who is sleeping with whom. Which Pirate Council member owes a debt to which merchant house. Which*

*harbourmaster is on three separate payrolls, and which informant changed sides on Thursday. You have built an empire of knowledge that nobody can see, and you protect it the way a spider protects a web: by being invisible, and by ensuring that anything that touches it gets stuck. The cards, the dice, the cons — those are the visible trade, and you are very good at them, but they were only ever apprenticeship. The real game taught you its one true rule early: everything in the Shackles is a wager, every person is a hand to be read, and the house — given enough patience, enough ledgers, enough friends in enough back rooms — the house is you. You only bet on certainties. The trick is manufacturing them.*

## CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Deceive
- ◆ DOMAIN: Port
- ◆ RESOURCE: A marked deck of cards D6 Port
- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Pick one:
  - ◆ Sleeve pistol Hunt D6, Ranged, One-Shot
  - ◆ Sword-cane Hunt D6, Brutal
  - ◆ Forger's kit of inks, seals and papers Deceive D6; sleeve-knife Hunt D6

## CORE ABILITIES

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### THE SURE THING

*Fate plays cards like everyone else; you palm its best card and keep it up your sleeve.* At any time, you may consume a resource and roll its dice; set the result aside. When you perform an action or inflict stress, but before you roll the dice to resolve it, you may replace any unrolled dice in your pool with the die you set aside. Once used in this manner, it is spent. If you have an unspent die set aside at the end of the session, mark Luck stress equal to the value showing on it.



## DOUBLE OR NOTHING

*Fate plays cards like everyone else, and like everyone else, it can be hustled.* At any time, roll a D6. If the result is equal to or under your current Luck stress, clear that much stress from Luck and roll with mastery on your next action. If it's over, add that much stress to Luck.

## MINOR ABILITIES

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### THE BRIBED HARBOUR

*Officials are just locks with salaries.* Gain the Colonial domain. In any port you have worked for at least a session, you keep an official in your pocket: once per session, they suppress a record, misdirect a pursuit or warn you when authority turns your way. They are real, have their own interests, and can be endangered if pushed.

### CARDSHARP'S FINGERS

*A moment of proximity, a moment of distraction.* Gain the Plunder skill. You can lift anything a person carries — keys, letters, the ring off their finger — given a moment of distraction; if the target is actively watching, roll Vanish, and on a partial success you take it but they notice something was wrong. Rigging a game of chance works the same way.

### CONTROLLED PROFILE

*The face people know is a construction; damaging it costs them effort and buys you time.* Gain +2 Reputation protection.

### EVERY ROOM'S NATIVE

*Tavern, council chamber, ship's mess or merchant ball.* Gain the Carouse skill. Roll with mastery when navigating social environments above or below your apparent station, because your station is whatever you need it to be right now.

## **FALSE FACE**

*Your real name is a question the GM answers only if you choose to.* Gain the Vanish skill. You maintain two working identities; switching between them takes only a moment — a different coat, a different posture, a different name. People who know one cannot connect it to the other without dedicated investigation.

## **LOADED DICE**

*You only bet on games you have already fixed.* Gain +2 Luck protection.

## **THE LONG GAME**

Gain access to one of the following skills: Carouse, Command, Deceive, Hunt, Navigate, Plunder, Reckon, Tend, Vanish. You can take this advance more than once.

## **THE LONG CON'S END**

*Every relationship you build is a position you can close. The mark who trusts you is the mark who lets you stand behind them.* Gain the Command skill. Once per session, when you attack a target you have cultivated over a scene or worked with THE HOOK, you roll with mastery and increase your stress dice by one step. They trusted you — that is the whole point.

## **NOSE FOR GOLD**

*There is always money nearby. It sings to you.* Gain the Outlaw domain. Once per session, ask the GM where the nearest source of wealth is and they will tell you.

## **OLD HAUNTS**

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Port, Colonial, Arcane. You can take this advance more than once.

## **TABLE STAKES**

Gain +1 Protection in the Tide, Reputation, Luck or Gold resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

## THE TELL

*New people are not new situations.* Gain the Reckon skill. When you observe someone for a few seconds, you can read their tells and discern their surface-level emotions — whether they're bluffing, frightened, greedy and so on.

## THE SLEEVE

*A pistol in the cuff, a blade in the cane, a needle behind the lapel. The trick was never the weapon. The trick is that no one searched the man buying them a drink.* Gain the Hunt skill. Regardless of searches, disarmament or the conventions of the room, you always have a small, concealed, sufficient weapon. When you strike someone who does not yet know you are a threat, your first attack gains the Brutal tag.

## MAJOR ABILITIES

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### THE HOOK

*Every mark already wants something. You just introduce them to it.* Roll Deceive+Port to work someone in conversation. On a success, you instil in them a fierce desire for something you have dangled — until the end of the current situation, they pursue it. If the desire is unusual for them, working the hook is Risky. - MINOR: THE DEEP HOOK. The desire lasts until the end of the session. If they don't get what they want by then, they descend into violence to acquire it or fall apart in despair — GM's choice. - MINOR: THE WHISPER CAMPAIGN. The desire spreads: anyone the mark talks to for more than a minute has a 1-in-6 chance of catching it. You are immune. Your allies are not. - MINOR: THE STANDING ARRANGEMENT. Mark D6 Luck stress to set the hook permanently: the first time the mark sees you each session, the desire rekindles, same as the day you planted it.

### EVERYBODY OWES

*Once you know what keeps someone awake at night, the rest is arithmetic.* Roll Reckon+Port on a target you can see and hear. On a success, you learn their deepest debt: the greatest thing they have ever taken from someone else — money, freedom, a name, a life. When you act on this information, roll with mastery. - MINOR: THE

**CREDITOR.** You also learn who the debt is owed to, and where to find them. The thread is easy enough to follow. - **MINOR: AN EVENING'S WORK.** Once per session, a night spent in the right rooms reveals someone nearby with an outstanding debt worth knowing. The GM tells you who. - **MINOR: THE BROKERED DEBT.** Once per session, sell what you know: introduce creditor to debtor on your terms, and clear D6 stress from Gold or Reputation as the grateful parties settle up around you.

## **THE WEB**

*You have a network, and the network has you.* Roll Deceive+Port to cultivate a contact in a port, faction or position, each with one type of information they can access — maritime traffic, colonial politics, criminal networks, arcane rumour. You can maintain three contacts at a time. Once per session, draw on a contact's information; each time you do, mark D4 stress to Gold or Reputation, or record a debt the GM may call in at the worst possible moment. - **MINOR: WIDE WEB.** You can maintain five contacts at a time. - **MINOR: THE FRIGHTENED FRIEND.** Once per session, a contact warns you of danger coming your way before it arrives — if anyone in your web could plausibly have seen it coming. - **MINOR: SPIDER'S PATIENCE.** When you act on a contact's information, roll with mastery.

## **THE CHEAP SHOT**

*They were fools to have trusted you.* When you attack a target who is unaware of your position with a one-handed melee weapon, your attacks gain the Piercing tag. - **MINOR: DEAD EYE.** The benefit also applies to ranged weapons. - **MINOR: NEVER SAW IT COMING.** Mark D4 stress to Luck to activate this power for your next use of **THE CHEAP SHOT**: your attack dice increases in size by two steps. **NEVER SAW IT COMING** only functions against a living person. - **MINOR: REMUNERATION.** When you reduce a target to 0 resistance using **THE CHEAP SHOT**, remove stress from Gold equal to double the value of your current tier.

## **THE BACK ROOM**

*As far as anyone knows, it's always been here.* When you are in a port, roll Deceive+Port to establish your back room — behind a gambling den, above a chart-

house, beneath a counting floor. Inside it, meetings happen on your terms: you roll with mastery on all social actions within. Your back room acts as a bond (see Ports & Haunts) — if it suffers fallout, a guest has been fleeced too hard, a secret has slipped its walls, or the law has taken an interest. - MINOR: THE HOUSE ALWAYS WINS. Once per session, the room's games and ledgers clear D4 Gold stress. - MINOR: WHAT THE WALLS HEARD. Once per session, the room yields a secret a guest let slip — the GM tells you something true and useful about anyone who has been inside this session. - MINOR: NEVER WAS. On a night's notice, the room vanishes: furniture, records, staff, all of it. Patrons misremember the address. Investigators find a storeroom that has clearly been empty for years.

## **ZENITH ABILITIES**

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### **THE WEB COMPLETES**

*It doesn't need you anymore.* Your network has become a force in the Shackles: it gathers, acts and remembers with or without your involvement. You may retire into being the spider at the centre, directing rather than doing — or burn the whole thing down in the most spectacular act of self-destruction these waters have seen, calling in every debt, exposing every secret, all at once. Either way, your character's story ends here: what you built is real, and the question of what it does without you watching now belongs to the campaign.

### **THE NAME BEHIND THE NAME**

*Everything that appeared to be coincidence was arrangement.* You reveal — to the table and the Shackles at the same moment — that you have been the hidden hand behind this arc's events: every obstacle manufactured, every ally cultivated, every escape permitted. The revelation is total and irreversible. You pass out of play and into the setting's machinery: from now on, nothing significant happens in the Shackles that you do not know about first, and the surviving characters live in a world where one of the powers watching them used to share their table.

## THE GRIFF ETERNAL

*You con death itself.* You stage your own death so perfectly that everyone is convinced — enemies, allies, creditors, the sea, and whatever keeps the ledgers beyond it. The Sharper everyone knew is mourned, buried, and settled into legend; every debt dies with the name. You walk away as someone new entirely — new face, new port, new game — and your character retires from play. The truth of where you went exists in exactly one place: a sealed file, held by the person at the table you trusted most. Whether they ever open it is up to them.

### SIN BOSUN

*Every ship has a sin bosun, whether the muster book records one or not. The crew might call them the padre, the holy, the god-botherer, the one who talks to the sky — what they mean is: the person you find when someone is dying, and also the person you find when you are lost. In the Shackles these have always been the same job, because the sea does not distinguish between a body it is killing and a ship it is sinking. You serve your god by moving through the world they made — Besmara who owns every plank that touches her water, Gozreh who is the wind in the sail and the storm against the hull, or something older and less named that speaks in current and depth. Your theology is practical: the god's domain is the sea, and to navigate it correctly — to read its weather, to know its routes, to bring ships and souls through it alive — is an act of worship. The chart is the scripture. The stars are the congregation. The passage completed is the prayer answered. You are not a soft priest. The sea is not kind, your god is not kind, and the mercy you offer is the specific, practical mercy of someone who has studied how to get people through things. You know the route. You know the rite. You know, better than most, that the difference between them is mostly a matter of what is doing the killing.*

## CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Navigate

- ◆ DOMAIN: Faith
- ◆ RESOURCE: A salt-stiffened prayer book interleaved with hand-drawn charts D6 Faith
- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Pick one:
  - ◆ Storm-lantern of blessed whale-oil Dark: Brave D6 / Lit: Brave D8, Obscuring, Dangerous
  - ◆ Breech-loading pistol and rite-knife Hunt D6, Ranged, Reload; Brave D6, Brutal
  - ◆ Scripture-inked bandages, blessed rum and a belaying pin Tend Blood D6; Brave D6

**Name your god at character creation.** The Shackles' faiths are Golarion's. **Besmara** the Pirate Queen — plunder, sea monsters and the Code — is the obvious patron. **Gozreh** is the wind in the sail and the storm against the hull. **Cayden Cailean** keeps the free, the brave and the drunk. **Pharasma** is owed the rites of the drowned. **Hei Feng** answers in thunder and sudden temper. Or serve something older and less named that speaks in current and depth. Establish what worship looks like aboard your ship and one thing the god requires of you — the GM speaks for the god through THE CHART AND THE PRAYER, CONFESSOR and your omens.

## CORE ABILITIES

### THE CHART AND THE PRAYER

*To you they are the same document: a chart more accurate than anything sold in the Shackles, and a record of every rite, omen and intervention you have witnessed on the water.* Once per session, when you consult it before acting, the GM gives you one true piece of information about what lies ahead — navigational, spiritual, or both. Once per journey, roll with mastery on a navigation challenge of your choosing.

## MINISTRATIONS

*You offer the practical mercy of someone who knows the words that settle debts between souls and the water.* Once per session, lead your allies in a rite — a sea burial, a blessing before battle, rum poured for the dead (how you practise your faith is up to you). All player characters who took part can remove one Minor Blood or Tide fallout, or downgrade one Major Blood or Tide fallout to Minor, at the end of the rite. If you perform this rite whilst on a journey, add +D4 to the journey's resistance.

## MINOR ABILITIES

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### CONFESSOR

*People tell you things. You asked the right way, or your presence drew it out of them — and when no one will speak, the sky still does.* Gain the Outlaw domain. Once per session, someone unburdens themselves to you: an NPC in port confesses a fear, a plan or a thing they have done that they cannot tell anyone else; or, read at night, the sky gives an omen about a specific person, ship or course of action. The GM chooses the medium and answers honestly — in plain words, or in astronomical metaphor. Your god has opinions about betrayal and about silence in roughly equal measure.

### DEAD RECKONING

*The bosun who lets the helmsman go down with fever loses the ship along with the soul.* Gain the Tend skill. You can treat exhaustion, exposure and the slow attrition of a hard passage with whatever is available at sea.

### DIVINE WARD

*Whatever is trying to curse you must first explain to your god why it thinks it has the right. The conversation takes long enough to matter.* Gain +2 Tide protection.

### THE GOD'S GIFTS

Gain access to one of the following skills: Brave, Carouse, Command, Endure, Hunt, Navigate, Plunder, Reckon, Tend. You can take this advance more than once.



## LAST RITES

*The god keeps what it is given properly.* Gain the Port domain. When you preside over a death — a funeral, a burial, a sailor gone over the side — you may ask the deceased's spirit a single question before your god takes it, and the dead so honoured cannot easily be raised against their will.

## LIAR'S BURDEN

*The sea does not tolerate false witness, and neither does your god.* Gain the Reckon skill. If you suspect an NPC is lying to you, roll Reckon+Faith. On a success, if they were lying, they mark D4 stress as their mouth fills with seawater.

## PILGRIM ROUTES

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Faith, Arcane, Port, Ruins. You can take this advance more than once.

## SACRED TATTOO

*Every passage survived is inked into your skin at the next port, a ledger the universe can read and finds balanced.* Gain +2 Luck protection.

## SCRIPTURE OF SALT

*You have argued the god's requirements with captains, cultists and the dying.* Gain the Command skill. When you invoke what the god requires in conversation with those who share — or fear — your faith, roll with mastery.

## SERMON ON THE DECK

*Your faith is shared meals, songs off-watch, and the last hour before a hard day.* Gain the Carouse skill. Once per session, when you drink, feast or mark a moment alongside an ally in the god's name, they gain +1 Tide protection until the end of the session.

## BLESSED STEEL

*The rite-knife that opens a sea-burial opens other things. The god does not mind which.* Gain the Brave skill. Your consecrated weapon — rite-knife, storm-lantern, belaying pin — is a true weapon in your hands. Once per situation, when you strike someone who has broken faith, oath or the Code — a mutineer, an oathbreaker, a desecrator — your attack gains the Brutal tag. The god keeps the books.

## UNWAVERING FAITH

Gain +1 Protection in the Tide, Reputation, Luck or Gold resistance. You can take this advance more than once.

## WEATHERWISE

*The best weather intelligence comes from the water itself: the temperature of the current, the smell of the air, the silence of the seabirds an hour before the squall.* Gain the Deepwater domain. When you have read the sea and sky before setting out, the first weather hazard of the journey inflicts its stress on you and your crew one dice size smaller.

## MAJOR ABILITIES

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### INTERCESSION

*You beseech your god on another's behalf. The god is not charitable. The god is interested in you, which is different, and considerably more useful.* Roll Tend+Faith to cast this spell. On a success, remove D6 stress from any resistance (other than Tide) for one nearby character other than yourself. - MINOR: THE BOSUN TOO.

INTERCESSION can now be used on yourself. - MINOR: TRANSFERRAL. Roll Tend+Faith to cast this spell; on a success, move a Minor fallout from any willing target other than yourself to any other willing target. Both targets must be within arm's reach of one another, and the receiving party must be able to bear the fallout. - MINOR: THE GOD DOES NOT DISTINGUISH. When you cast TRANSFERRAL, the target receiving the fallout does not have to be willing to receive it. Casting the spell in this way uses the target's difficulty instead of standard difficulty.

## THE HUNGRY CHURCH

*Your faith has taken root: pirates, fisherfolk and dockworkers who acknowledge your god through you.* When in a port, roll Command+Faith to cast this spell as you consecrate a shrine and gather the faithful; on a success, add the port to your church. When you enter a port that is part of your church, gain a D4 (Faith) resource. Increase the dice size of this resource by one step for every additional port in the church after the first, to a maximum of D10. - MINOR: TITHE. The faithful contribute out of something between gratitude and insurance. Once per session, whilst at a port in your church, clear D4 Gold stress. - MINOR: EYES OF THE FAITHFUL. Your congregation notices things that feel wrong before they become things they can name. Once per session, whilst at a port in your church, ask the GM what your church has sensed that would be useful to you. They always know something. It is rarely comforting. - MINOR: RITE OF SAFE HARBOUR. Whilst you are at a port in your church, you and your allies gain +1 Tide protection, and attacking you on consecrated ground is a divine transgression — the aggressor immediately marks D4 Tide stress.

## THE NAME SPOKEN OVER WATER

*You have learned one of the secret names of your god, and when you speak it across open water your enemies are struck senseless by its weight.* The name functions as the following weapon: (Brave D6, Spread, Debilitating, Maddening, One-Shot). - MINOR: THE WAVE'S WEIGHT. The weapon gains the Brutal tag. - MINOR: THE FOG'S QUIET. The weapon gains the Smoke tag (it manifests like fog rolling off cold water) and no longer creates noise — in fact, it dampens all nearby noise. - MINOR: THE TIDE'S MERCY. When you speak THE NAME SPOKEN OVER WATER, you and all nearby allies remove D4 stress from Blood.

## THE PERFECT COURSE

*Complete navigational and spiritual preparation, meeting complete competency. The god clears the way for those who have done the work of being ready.* Once per session, roll Navigate+Faith to chart a course that accounts for everything — weather, current, spiritual hazard, divine attention. On a success, the chart functions as a D8

boon on the journey, and when the journey's worst peril arrives, you saw it coming: you and your crew roll with mastery against it. - MINOR: PURSUIT COURSE. Your course can be charted to intercept a named vessel. If you know roughly where it started, roll with mastery on rolls to run it down. - MINOR: ESCAPE COURSE. Your course can be charted to shake pursuit. Increase the stress you inflict on pursuing vessels by one step. - MINOR: THE IMPOSSIBLE PASSAGE. Once per campaign, THE PERFECT COURSE can take a ship through genuinely impassable waters — the edge of the Eye of Abendego, a divine boundary, waters the charts name as void. The god permits what the god permits. You have asked correctly.

## **STORM CALLING**

*This is not magic. This is asking the god to do what the god does, and having the relationship that means the god agrees.* Roll Endure+Faith and mark D8 Tide stress to call a storm in your god's name. It arrives within a few hours, is severe, and lasts until you release it or D6 hours pass, whichever comes first. You can direct it broadly: toward a fleet, away from a harbour, into a specific stretch of ocean. Ships caught in the storm mark D8 Hull stress whenever they fail or partially succeed on an action to sail, fight or free themselves within it — and whenever the GM judges the storm simply finds them. - MINOR: THE EYE. You can create a zone of calm within your storm where your vessel sails safely. Enemies who follow you into the calm mark D8 Hull stress for every action they take to do so. - MINOR: LIGHTNING. Once per situation within your storm, call a strike on a target you can see: D10 Blood or Hull stress. The god's aim is not always precise. It is always intentional. - MINOR: RIDER OF THE STORM. While within a storm you have called, you take no stress from weather effects and roll with mastery on all navigation and shipboard actions. You asked for this. You are ready for it.

## **ZENITH ABILITIES**

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### **THE GOD'S CHAMPION**

*The god has been arranging this since before you were born.* Once, you may act in your god's name with their full power behind you. The effect is mythic: a storm that

swallows a fleet, a passage opened through waters closed for a century, a blessing that turns a dying ship into something that refuses to sink. Afterwards, the god's agenda is yours, completely and without reservation — you sail where it sends you, beyond the edges of the campaign. Whether this is the highest expression of freedom — doing exactly what you were made for — or the final surrender of it, is the question your arc has been building toward.

## SAINT OF THE DROWNED

*To activate this ability, die at sea, settling a debt the water was owed.* The place where you went down becomes holy: a sea-mark every sailor in the Shackles comes to know, where the water is calm when it has no right to be and no one drowns who does not deserve it. Over the following months, mariners leave offerings over the spot. For the remainder of the campaign, the sea-mark functions as a landmark with appropriate haunts. Once per campaign, when the surviving player characters sail over it, they can beseech your spirit for a true heading. You will deliver valuable wisdom.

## THE WAY THROUGH

*The sea opens for you.* Once, you can navigate anywhere: through the heart of the Eye, into waters no chart has reached, to a place that exists only because your god made it and you are the only one who knows the way. Where you go and what you find is the final question your arc has been asking. The god promised passage to those who served it. You have served it. The passage is real. Whether coming back is part of it is a question the god has not answered, and may not answer until you arrive. Your character leaves the story.

## TIDECALLER

*The Eye of Abendego did not form by accident. Something lives at the heart of that immortal storm — ancient, patient, and interested in very specific things. You found it, or it found you. The terms were unclear. They remain unclear. What is clear is what you got: the wild magic of the ocean and the bargained, familiar-haunted power of the*

*witch tradition, braided into one trade — and what it is costing you, a little at a time. Your blood runs colder than it used to. Salt crusts where you sleep. There are mornings when your reflection takes a moment too long to do what you did. Crews fear you and captains court you, because a witch aboard is luck and weather and hexes turned aside, and everyone has heard what happens to ships that put one over the side. You are treated as something between an officer and an omen. They are right to do so. You are not entirely sure, anymore, which side of the bargain you are standing on — whether you are a person who commands the sea's power, or a place where the sea is slowly coming ashore.*

## CORE TRAITS

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- ◆ SKILL: Command
- ◆ DOMAIN: Arcane
- ◆ RESOURCE: A jar of storm-water from the Eye that never stops spinning D6 Arcane
- ◆ EQUIPMENT: Pick one:
  - ◆ Coral-hilted ritual knife Brave D6, Bloodbound
  - ◆ Salvaged carbine, shot etched with wave-sigils Hunt D6, Ranged, Reload
  - ◆ Sea-chest of brines, weeds and leeches Tend Blood D6

## CORE ABILITIES

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### THE PACT

*It is real, it has wants, and it speaks in signs rather than words.* At character creation, name your pact entity — something drawn from the Eye, the deeps, or the storm. Once per session, ask it one direct question; the GM answers honestly, in the language of omens. When you act in accordance with what it wants, remove D4 Tide stress. When you act against it, mark D6 Tide stress.

## SEA-CHANGE

*Your body is half the sea's already.* Whenever you want to, or when you suffer Major fallout, you enter your true form — scaled, kelp-wreathed, eyes like drowned moons; describe it. In your true form, you roll with mastery on Brave and Hunt checks, but all other checks become Risky. At the end of the current situation, you revert to your mortal shape.

## MINOR ABILITIES

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### BLOOD-QUIET

*The deep water beats black within your veins.* Gain the Vanish skill. When you are in your SEA-CHANGE form, Vanish rolls are no longer Risky.

### DEEPSPEAK

*Not language — intent and image.* Gain the Faith domain. Besmara's sacred animals treat you as kin, and once per session you can put one question to a sea-creature about what it has seen or sensed nearby; it answers as best its small mind allows.

### THE DROWNED PLACES

*The sea showed you where it keeps what it takes.* Gain the Ruins domain. Once per session, ask the GM whether anything drowned — wreck, ruin or sunken thing — lies beneath your keel and they will tell you; the pact then lets you breathe water for the rest of the situation to walk its halls.

### FAMILIAR

*A gull, a crab, a serpentine thing that shouldn't exist.* Gain the Hunt skill. You have a bound creature that serves as your eyes and messenger; it can travel up to a day's sail from you and return, and you can mark D4 Tide stress to see through its senses.

## HEX SIGHT

*You can smell a working the way sailors smell weather.* Gain the Reckon skill. You always know when you are in the presence of active magic, curses or supernatural attention; identifying its nature is a Reckon roll, made with mastery.

## OLD WATERS

Gain access to one of the following domains: Deepwater, Shallows, Outlaw, Arcane, Faith, Ruins, Wilderness. You can take this advance more than once.

## THE PRIOR CLAIM

*Whatever tries to curse you must first negotiate with the thing that holds the lien.* Gain +2 Tide protection.

## SALT-TAUGHT

Gain access to one of the following skills: Brave, Command, Deceive, Endure, Hunt, Navigate, Reckon, Tend, Vanish. You can take this advance more than once.

## STORM-DEBT

*The weather owes you, and you collect in instalments.* Gain the Deepwater domain. Once per session, while at sea, call a weather working — a squall, a fog bank, a sudden calm. It costs nothing and lasts until the end of the situation.

## TIDEBLOOD

*What would fester on land closes clean in open water.* Gain the Endure skill. Once per session, when you immerse yourself in seawater after taking Blood stress, remove D4 Blood stress. You can survive underwater twice as long as a normal person.

## WARDED AND WATCHED

Gain +1 Protection in the Blood, Tide, Reputation or Luck resistance. You can take this advance more than once.



## THE WITCH'S DUE

*No one laughs twice.* Gain +2 Reputation protection.

## WITCH'S HANDS

*The sea is a pharmacopoeia for those it has claimed, and you have learned to share what it gives you.* Gain the Tend skill. When you have time to prepare, you can turn a resource with the Deepwater or Wilderness domain into a draught; when drunk, it removes Blood or Tide stress equal to its dice size minus one step — choose which when you brew it. In addition, once per situation you may treat a nearby ally directly with sea-physick, removing D4 Blood stress without a prepared draught.

## MAJOR ABILITIES

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### BRINE CALLS TO BRINE

*You call to the salt in their blood, and it answers by leaving.* This spell functions as a weapon with the following profile: (Hunt D6, Ranged). You can mark stress accrued as a result of using this spell to Tide. - MINOR: RETCH. The stress dice increases to D8. - MINOR: MAESTRO. The weapon gains the Piercing tag. - MINOR: AS ABOVE, SO BELOW. You do not need line of sight as long as you have a sympathetic token of your target — their hair, a carving in their shape, a favoured possession — but you are still limited to the usual distance of the Ranged tag.

### THE SCRYING BOWL

*You bleed into a bowl of seawater, and omens swim in the clouding.* Roll Reckon+Arcane to cast this spell before you embark on a voyage. On a success, you see three omens; describe them — the vaguer, the better. They are fated to come up on the voyage, and the first time you interact with whatever each omen concerns, you roll with mastery. - MINOR: SHARED VISIONS. Your allies also roll with mastery when they interact with the portentous things. - MINOR: SCARLET INSIGHT. Once per session, when you cast this spell, clear D8 stress from Tide or Luck. - MINOR: DIRE PORTENTS. Once per session, re-roll any dice that you or anyone else rolled — the original roll was a vision you received, and you shout the warning in time.

## **GREAT AND TERRIBLE**

*The sea stops borrowing your shape and starts wearing it proudly.* You are no longer forced into your SEA-CHANGE form when you take Major fallout. When you choose to enter your true form, all adversaries who can see you mark D4 stress. - MINOR: ENTHRALL. When you enter your true form, you may mark D4 Tide stress; all who see you transform are stunned into inaction, and you have time to make a single action entirely unopposed. - MINOR: SLOUGH. Once per session, when you assume your true form, downgrade one Blood fallout you are suffering by one step — the wound stays behind on the shed skin. - MINOR: UNION. Once per situation, when you are in your true form and an action would be Risky, treat it as Standard instead.

## **THE TIDE COMES IN**

*You sing the sea into the space around you.* Roll Command+Arcane to cast this spell and draw the ocean's attention into the area: tide-pools where there was dry deck, fog that moves against the wind, barnacles blooming on stone. The area gains the Arcane domain and reacts appropriately until the end of the current situation. - MINOR: BYPASS. The first time you cast this spell on a voyage, it functions as a D6 boon. - MINOR: BLOOD CALLS FOR BLOOD. All weapons used in the area increase their stress dice by 1 step — for adversaries and player characters alike. - MINOR: REFUGE. Clear D6 Luck stress from yourself or an ally each time you cast this spell.

## **THE SEA'S MANY BODIES**

*The pact does not much care which body you use.* Roll Command+Arcane to send your spirit into a sea creature you can see — a shark, an octopus, a gull riding the same wind. On a success, you direct it to perform basic tasks, though the control is imperfect. Your body slumps where you left it, and you come to when your spirit returns. At the end of the situation, the creature dies; the sea collects its fee. - MINOR: THE BORROWED MOUTH. The creature can speak with your voice — negotiate, threaten, deliver a message from somewhere no one expected. - MINOR: THE SHOAL. You can ride a shoal, swarm or flock as a single body, moving as a cloud of

eyes and teeth. - MINOR: LEVIATHAN VESSEL. Once per campaign, the vessel can be something truly vast. The GM determines what the deep sends when you ask.

## **ZENITH ABILITIES**

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### **THE PACT FULFILLED**

*The entity calls in everything, and at last you understand the terms.* You may accept or refuse. If you accept: the working is titanic — a storm that swallows a fleet, a sea-change that redraws a coastline, a hex that lays a city low — and you cease to be entirely human; how much of you remains is a question the table answers together. If you refuse: the pact shatters, you lose every ability of this class permanently, and you are free — truly, completely free — of every supernatural claim on you. Both answers end your arc. There was never a third.

### **SOVEREIGN OF THE DROWNED**

*The Eye itself acknowledges you.* Once, you may speak a permanent working into the world — a change to the Shackles that outlasts you: a new current, a dead reef come alive, an island that appears only for those who need it, a named ship that sails forever without a crew. The GM incorporates it as a permanent truth of the setting. You retire into legend — the witch the working is named for, spoken of in the same breath as the weather.

### **WHAT THE EYE KEEPS**

*You sail into the Eye of Abendego and do not come out. Something else happens instead.* Choose a stretch of sea — a strait, a reef-maze, the waters around one island. You are omnipresent within it: while the situation lasts, you choose who lives and who drowns inside its borders. When the situation ends, the water is stained with you forever: it counts as one tier stranger than it was, its weather answers to no chart, and sailors learn to speak kindly when crossing it. You live on as the thing the locals leave offerings for. In a generation, someone desperate will stand at its edge and ask for terms. You will be interested in very specific things.

# ANCESTRIES — WHO YOU ARE

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Your ancestry is who you are *before the dice hit the table*. It tells the crew where you come from, how the world has treated you, and what ghosts you carry onto a pirate deck. It is the third pillar of a character, beside your **Class** (what you can do) and your **Calling** (why you sail) — and unlike those two, it is **purely narrative**.

**An ancestry answers: who are you? Where do you come from? Why are you here? It never answers: what can you do?**

## ANCESTRIES GRANT NO MECHANICS

No bonuses, no abilities, no protection, no modifiers — none. The storm does not care whether you are a Bonuwat free-diver or a brass automaton; the sea drowns everyone the same. What an ancestry gives you is *texture*: a place in the Shackles' web of power, a reason you ended up at the edge of the world, and a fistful of objects that imply a life. Everything you can *do* comes from your class and your calling. This is a deliberate inheritance from the Resistance system: a question about *who you are* should never become a question about *which combination is strongest*.

## TWO KINDS OF ANCESTRY

The peoples of the Shackles fall into two groups, and they answer the "who are you" question differently.

**Cultures** are for the "baseline" folk of the Inner Sea — **humans, elves, half-elves, and the like**. For these peoples, species barely matters; what matters is the *culture* that raised you. **There is no "human" or "elf" ancestry in this game** — instead you choose a culture pool, and your exact species within it is yours to picture. A Chelaxian may be human or elf; a Shackleborn is whatever blood the islands have mixed. Pick the upbringing, not the bloodline.

**Kindreds** are peoples set apart by their very nature — their bodies, instincts, or origins mark them out, and they carry their own culture with them wherever the tide takes them. A kindred *is* your people.

CULTURES

| CULTURE     | IN A LINE                                    | STANDS WHERE, IN THE WEB OF POWER                                    |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shackleborn | Born to the islands, of every blood and none | The sea is home, not escape                                          |
| Bonuwat     | The Mwangi coast's own seafarers             | Indigenous to these waters; dispossessed by everyone who charts them |
| Chelaxian   | Children of the empire, turned against it    | Colonial and privileged origin, now in exile                         |

# KINDREDS

| KINDRED      | GATHERS                                    | IN A LINE                                                             |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Small Folk   | Halflings, gnomes, dwarves                 | The small "ordinary" peoples — overlooked, and armoured by it         |
| Goblinkin    | Goblins, kobolds                           | The small the world calls <i>vermin</i> — hunted, and gleefully alive |
| Big Folk     | Half-orcs, minotaurs, hobgoblins           | The large and martial — feared on land, valued on a deck              |
| The Made     | Androids, automatons, homunculi            | Built rather than born, and claiming a self anyway                    |
| Beast-folk   | Tengu, catfolk, ratfolk, merfolk, naga     | Animal shape, animal instinct, thinking mind                          |
| Planetouched | Tieflings, aasimars, the elemental-blooded | Marked by a heritage they did not choose                              |

## HOW TO USE AN ANCESTRY

At character creation (Part Eight, Step 4):

1. **Read** your culture's or kindred's lore.

2. **Answer one** of its three background questions, out loud, at the table. Each names real places, factions, and people of the Shackles — engaging with the world is the point.
3. **Choose a name** (each lists examples and how names work).
4. **Roll twice on the d20 trinkets table** and keep both. They are not equipment — they are evidence.

## BUILDING YOUR OWN — AND WHAT'S COMING

Ancestries are mechanics-free, so making one with your GM is easy: follow the Ancestry Design Guide (lore block · three world-anchored questions · names · a d20 trinkets table). Add a **culture** by naming a new upbringing (the inland **Mwangi**, the elf-courts of the **Mordant Spire**, a **Vudrani** or **Tian** trade-diaspora). Add another **kindred** by naming a people apart, or a **culture** by naming a new upbringing.

**One deliberate omission:** there is no "drowned" or deep-folk ancestry. Being claimed by the sea and coming back as something not-quite-human is the gravest stake of the **Tide** track and the **Cursed Tides** calling. If you could simply *start* as one of the deep's own, that fate would stop being frightening. The drowned remain a destination, never a starting point.

## SHACKLEBORN

*A culture, not a species. There is no "human" or "elf" ancestry in this game — those peoples are defined by the culture that raised them, and the Shackleborn are whatever blood the islands have mixed: human, elf, half-elf, and every other baseline folk born to the tide.*

You were born somewhere between two tides, on an island that flies no nation's flag, to parents who were themselves the leavings of a dozen coasts — a little Chelish, a little Mwangi, a little Tian, a little of whatever sailor passed through the season you were made. The Shackleborn are not an ancestry of blood but of place: the creole people of the islands, raised on salt fish and the Pirate Code, who learned to swim before they learned to walk and to lie before they learned to read. You have never had a homeland to lose, because the sea between the islands is the only home there has ever been. Outsiders call the Shackles lawless; you know it has more laws than anywhere, they are simply not written down, and breaking them costs more. You do not dream of escaping to a better life elsewhere — there is no elsewhere that would have you, and you would not go.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ You came up in the alleys and wharves of **Port Peril**, running messages and lifting purses before you could shave. Whose crew or gang raised you in place of the parents you barely remember — and what do you still owe them?
- ◆ You were one of dozens of children aboard a single great pirate vessel, raised collectively by a crew who were closer than any blood. Something happened to that ship and most of that crew. What was it, and what do you carry from it?
- ◆ You grew up in a tiny anchorage on a forgotten island, far from **Quent** or any place that matters, and left the day a ship would take you. What were you running toward, and what did you swear you'd never become?

## NAMES

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Shackleborn names are magpie things, stitched from every culture that ever made port: a Chelish given name, a Mwangi surname, a nickname earned in a tavern that outlives both. Most go by the nickname. Examples: *Cinder*, *Marisol Okonkwo*, *Tam Greel*, *Quintana*, *Bilge-Rat Ojo*, *Sefa "Two-Knives" Castellan*.



Many Shackleborn are renamed at least once by a crew — a deed-name or an insult that stuck. The birth name becomes a thing you only tell people you trust.

## TRINKETS

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*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                     |
|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | A child's drawing of a ship, kept folded so long the creases are soft as cloth              |
| 2   | A string of mismatched buttons, each one cut from the coat of a different dead man          |
| 3   | The Pirate Code, copied out in your own crooked hand, with two articles you added yourself  |
| 4   | A worn knucklebone die that has never once rolled a one for you                             |
| 5   | A key to a door on an island that has since burned down                                     |
| 6   | A scar across your palm from the oath that made you part of your first crew                 |
| 7   | Your share-token from your first real prize, drilled through and worn on a cord             |
| 8   | A pet harbour rat, fat and clever and utterly loyal (name it)                               |
| 9   | A tin whistle that plays the three tunes every Shackles child knows                         |
| 10  | A list of every port you've made, with a private mark beside the ones you can't go back to  |
| 11  | A wanted notice — yours — that gets the spelling of your name wrong, which you find funny   |
| 12  | A length of rope tied in the particular knot your mother used; you don't know what it means |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                       |
|-----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 13  | A handful of foreign coins, none of them legal tender anywhere you've been                    |
| 14  | A shark-tooth charm, given for luck by someone who then had none                              |
| 15  | A cork from the first bottle you were ever allowed to finish                                  |
| 16  | A folding knife worn paper-thin from sharpening, that you will never replace (name it)        |
| 17  | A letter of marque you stole, blank where the captain's name should be                        |
| 18  | A small idol of Besmara, the paint long worn off her face                                     |
| 19  | A bird's skull, a sea-glass bead, a brass screw — the pockets of someone who keeps everything |
| 20  | A debt-marker in your own hand, owed to a person you can no longer find                       |

## BONUWAT

*A culture, not a species. Most Bonuwat are human, but the coast has long taken in elves, half-elves, and others who learned its waters; what makes you Bonuwat is the shore that raised you, not the shape of your blood.*

Your people are the coast itself made into a nation — the seafaring folk of the western Mwangi shore, who were reading the currents and free-diving the reefs of these waters long before the first Chelish keel cut through them. To be Bonuwat is to belong to the

sea in a way the colonisers will never understand and never stop trying to buy. You know the names of currents the charts do not record, the reefs that move, the islands that are only there at certain tides. The Aspis Consortium and the Chelish navy carved up your coast for timber, ivory, and worse, and called it trade; your grandparents called it what it was. Some of your people went pirate to take it all back one prize at a time; some went pirate because there was nothing left of the old life to stay for. Either way, the deep remembers you, and you have never once felt alone on the water.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ A slaving operation working out of **Bloodcove** took people from your village — perhaps including you, before you got free. You sail in part to make that trade bleed. What did you lose to it, and how close have you come to the ones responsible?
- ◆ You were a pilot and free-diver whose knowledge of the reefs was worth a fortune, and a Free Captain offered you a berth rather than a chain for it. Which captain, and do you trust the bargain you struck?
- ◆ You left the coast willingly, drawn by a story the elders tell about something out beyond the charted water — a drowned place, a debt the sea is owed, a song under the waves. What did you go looking for, and has the sea begun to answer?

## NAMES

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Bonuwat names carry weight — a birth name from the family, and often a second name earned from the sea itself: a thing you survived, a creature you faced, a reef you alone can run. Examples: *Adaeze*, *Kofi Reef-Walker*, *Ngozi*, *Seun*, *Yetunde Deep-Breath*, *Abara Two-Tides*.

Many Bonuwat sailors take a sea-name in addition to their birth name; it is the sea-name that is used among a crew, and the birth name that is used among kin.

# TRINKETS

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*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                          |
|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | A free-diver's weight-belt of carved stone beads, each one a depth you have reached and survived |
| 2   | A pouch of indigo dye worth more than most pirates carry in coin, that you will not sell         |
| 3   | A reef-map drawn on dried sharkskin, in a notation only your people read                         |
| 4   | A grandmother's earring, the match to which a Chelish factor wears and does not know its meaning |
| 5   | A whistle carved from a great fish's bone, that carries underwater                               |
| 6   | A scar in the shape of a creature's teeth, from the dive that earned your sea-name               |
| 7   | A bill of sale — your own, voided — that you kept instead of burning                             |
| 8   | A length of net you can mend in the dark, knot-perfect, the last your village made               |
| 9   | A small living thing that rode home on your shoulder from a far reef (name it)                   |
| 10  | A jar of coast-water from the exact place you were born, going slowly stale                      |
| 11  | A list of the drowned, recited each new moon, that you have added to in your own hand            |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                  |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 12  | A diving-knife so old the bone handle has taken the shape of your grip (name it)         |
| 13  | A piece of pale coral that grew in the shape of a hand                                   |
| 14  | A Consortium survey-stake, pulled up and kept, with their mark you've half-scratched out |
| 15  | A song you are the last living person who knows                                          |
| 16  | A bracelet of shark teeth, one of them not from any shark you can name                   |
| 17  | An offering-bowl for Gozreh, salt-crustured, used every dawn you can manage it           |
| 18  | A sealed letter to an elder back home that you have never found a ship to carry          |
| 19  | A child's first diving-stone, that you are keeping for someone not yet old enough        |
| 20  | A pearl the size of a knuckle, the price of which is the thing you can never tell        |

## CHELAXIAN

*A culture, not a species. Chelish society is mostly human, with old elven and half-elven houses woven through its bloodlines; you are Chelaxian by upbringing and bearing, whatever your ancestry beneath it.*

You were raised in the long shadow of the most disciplined and devil-haunted empire of the Inner Sea — pale, schooled, and taught from infancy that order is worth any price, including your soul and everyone else's. Cheliox made you to be useful: a naval officer, a factor's clerk, a duelist of good family, a cog in a machine that runs on contracts signed in something darker than ink. And then something broke the spell — a press-ganging, a disgrace, a conscience that arrived too late or right on time — and you ran for the one place in the world the empire cannot reach. You brought your education with you, which is more useful at sea than you would like to admit; you can forge a manifest, read a man-o-war's signals, and pass for a magistrate's adjutant in a way no Free Captain ever could. But the accent marks you, and so does the flinch when someone mentions a name you used to answer to.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ You served aboard a Chelish man-o-war out of **Corentyn** before your ship was taken — and the Free Captains offered you a berth instead of the deep. What did you do to earn that, when your fellow officers earned a knife?
- ◆ You fled a contract — an indenture, a betrothal, a debt sworn before a devil — that is still, technically, legally binding. Who in Cheliox still holds your paper, and what will it cost when they send someone to collect?
- ◆ You came to the Shackles believing in the empire and meaning to bring it order, and somewhere along the way you changed sides for real. What did you see that turned you, and who from your old life would put a price on your head if they knew?

## NAMES

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Chelish names are formal, layered, and faintly archaic — a given name, a house name, often a saint's or ancestor's name carried like a debt. Out here you have probably shortened it, or thrown away the house name entirely. Examples: *Aurelio Thrune-by-marriage*, *Severa*, *Maddox Vell*, *Cordelia Anvanus*, *Just "Vespers," Tace Drovost*.



A Chelish family name still opens doors and closes throats across the Inner Sea. Many defectors drop theirs and keep only a given name — but the ones hunting them know the old one.

## TRINKETS

---

*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                           |
|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | A signet ring of a noble house, filed flat so the crest no longer reads                           |
| 2   | A naval officer's spyglass, regulation issue, with your old rank still engraved                   |
| 3   | A letter of indenture or betrothal, the seal broken, that you cannot quite bring yourself to burn |
| 4   | A duelling glove of fine leather, kept for a challenge you intend to deliver one day              |
| 5   | A child's catechism of the empire, annotated in the margins by a younger, truer believer          |
| 6   | A vial of holy-or-unholy water you can no longer remember which                                   |
| 7   | A miniature portrait of someone you left, painted so well it still hurts to open                  |
| 8   | A set of forger's tools — fine nibs, official wax, a stolen seal-matrix                           |
| 9   | A medal for service you are now ashamed of, that you keep to stay ashamed                         |
| 10  | A contract written in a hand that is not human, that you took when you ran                        |
| 11  | A clever folding razor, monogrammed, that has shaved three captains and cut one throat            |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                           |
|-----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 12  | A cipher-key to a code the Chelish navy used the year you deserted                                                |
| 13  | A pressed flower from a garden in Egorian that no longer exists                                                   |
| 14  | A worn copy of the duelling forms, every page memorised, carried out of habit                                     |
| 15  | A debt-marker you hold against a Chelish officer who does not yet know you survived                               |
| 16  | A small, expensive, useless thing — a porcelain cat, a jewelled thimble — that you stole on the way out (name it) |
| 17  | A list of the names of everyone your old ship took, that you are slowly trying to find                            |
| 18  | A confessor's stole, taken from a man who would not have given it                                                 |
| 19  | A perfectly tailored coat, salt-ruined now, that you wear anyway                                                  |
| 20  | A sealed letter of confession you have written but not decided whether to send                                    |

## SMALL FOLK

*A kindred, not one people: halflings, gnomes, dwarves, and every other small civilised folk the Inner Sea reckons "ordinary" — as opposed to the goblins and kobolds it calls vermin.*

You are one of the small peoples — the ones the tall world finds useful, underestimates, and forgets to fear. Maybe you are a **halfling**, born into a Chelish household that owned you or one generation removed from one, who got over a wall and never looked back. Maybe you are a **gnome**, fey-touched and restless, forever one new wonder ahead of the grey creeping numbness your people call the Bleaching, and the deck of a pirate ship is the most interesting thing you have ever found. Maybe you are a **dwarf**, exiled from the stone-holds by oath or feud or sheer wanderlust, carrying your craft and your grudges out onto a sea your ancestors never trusted. What you share is not blood but *position*: you are small in a world built for the big, and you have learned that being overlooked is a kind of armour, and that the small hands get into the places the large ones cannot.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ You came up under a roof that did not consider you a full person — a Chelish estate near **Corentyn**, an Aspis counting-house in **Bloodcove**, a dwarf-hold that cast you out. Who decided your size was the same as your worth, and how close have they come to finding you since?
- ◆ You are chasing something the tall world doesn't value enough to guard properly — a wonder, a craft, a freedom, a debt of honour older than anyone alive. What is it, and what has the chase already cost you?
- ◆ You were born free in the Shackles, small among giants, and learned early that the deck doesn't care how tall you are if your hands are quick and your nerve holds. Who taught you that, and what did you have to prove to them?

## NAMES

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Small Folk names span their peoples: halfling names are warm and plain, often a trade or a place (*Pim Saltcellar*, *Lula*, *Mosey*); gnome names are long, musical, and collected like keepsakes, usually shortened by everyone else (*Fonkin*, *Zither*, *Bee*); dwarf names are hard and clan-bound, an honorific or a hold attached (*Hekka*

*Stonebound, Durgan, Vess Oath-Kept*). Examples across the kindred: *Pim, Bee Quick-Fingers, Durgan No-Hold, Hessa Freeborn, Tock, Corrin Tallows*.

Many Small Folk carry two names — the one their people gave them and the one the tall world can be bothered to pronounce. Halflings born to bondage often choose a free name on getting out; gnomes change theirs whenever the old one stops delighting them.

## TRINKETS

---

*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                               |
|-----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | A household tag, collar, or hold-brand — cut through, filed off, or pried loose — kept as a reminder of what you left |
| 2   | A recipe, a formula, or a clan-mark recorded in three hands: your grandmother's, your mother's, and now yours         |
| 3   | A skeleton key you cut yourself, that opens more than it has any right to                                             |
| 4   | A tiny, intricate, useless mechanism — a gnome's whim — that does one charming thing and nothing else                 |
| 5   | A page torn from a ledger, an oath-tablet, or a property-roll with your old name on it, stolen on the way out         |
| 6   | A set of weighted dice you only use on people who deserve it                                                          |
| 7   | A list of names — others still inside the house, hold, or cage you escaped — that you are working down, one at a time |
| 8   | A small animal that runs the rat-lines and answers only to you (name it)                                              |
| 9   | A free-paper or forged writ of passage, made out to a person who never existed                                        |
| 10  | A spoon, a chisel, or a thimble worn thin — the one tool of your old life that made it out with you                   |
| 11  | An iron token of Cayden Cailean, patron of the freed, that you rub before anything dangerous                          |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                               |
|-----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 12  | A wanted notice offering a reward "for the return of property," meaning you, that you carry out of spite              |
| 13  | A coil of fine cord and a grapple small enough to hide in a fist                                                      |
| 14  | A pressed sprig, a chip of stone, or a fading sketch of the one good thing from where you grew up                     |
| 15  | A pouch of something the Bleaching can't touch — a colour, a song, a joke — that a gnome carries against the grey     |
| 16  | A whistle-code, taught by runaways or by miners, that means <i>get out now</i> in any place that knows it             |
| 17  | A debt owed you by someone you freed or saved, who swore they'd come when you called                                  |
| 18  | A craftsman's kit — needle and palm, files and picks, lockwork tools — small enough to vanish, good enough to live on |
| 19  | A jar of good salt or fine ale, because you swore you would never again take what they handed you                     |
| 20  | The first coin you ever earned as your own person, that you will starve before you spend                              |

## GOBLINKIN

*A kindred, not one people: goblins, kobolds, and the other small folk the Inner Sea does not call "ordinary" but "vermin" — and hunts accordingly.*

You are small like the halflings and gnomes, but where the world merely *overlooks* them, it actively wants you *dead*. Maybe you are a **goblin** — sharp-toothed, fire-mad, gleefully alive — raised in a warren that the nearest town burned out at least once in your memory, who learned that the only safe place is moving and the only currency is being too useful or too funny to kill. Maybe you are a **kobold** — scaled, clever, and proud — bred to traps and tunnels and the worship of things much larger than yourself, until you slipped your warren's hierarchy and struck out to be nobody's small and expendable cog. The respectable peoples treat you as a problem with legs; the Free Captains, gloriously, do not care, so long as you can fit down the hawsehole to clear a fouled cable, rig a trap no boarder expects, or do the loud dangerous thing nobody taller will volunteer for. You have spent your whole life being underestimated and hunted. On a pirate deck, for the first time, the first half is an advantage and the second half is just *Tuesday*.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ A town, a baron, or a "pest-control" bounty out of a colonial port like **Bloodcove** put a price on your whole warren — maybe on you specifically. What happened to the rest of them, and what did you do that they still remember?
- ◆ You are dangerously, delightedly good at the thing that scares everyone else — fire, traps, heights, the powder magazine, the narrow flooded crawlspace. What's your specialty, and what has it already cost you or someone near you?
- ◆ You attached yourself to this crew the way your kind always survives: by being indispensable to someone bigger. Who did you decide to be useful to, do they know it's mutual, and what happens the day they stop needing you?

## NAMES

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Goblin names are short, percussive, and often gross or boastful, earned and re-earned by deeds (*Snag, Chuff, Reekfinger, Last*); kobold names hiss and click, frequently invoking a draconic patron or a clever trap they're proud of (*Skritt, Vex, Az-the-Snare*,



*Little Tooth*). Examples across the kindred: *Snag*, *Skritt*, *Reek*, *Vex Trapwright*, *Chuff*, *Az*.

Goblins rename themselves constantly — after a meal, a fire, a near-death — and sing the new name until it sticks. Kobolds guard their true-name and offer the surface a use-name, often the name of the trap or trick they're best at.

## TRINKETS

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*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                         |
|-----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | A tinderbox you made yourself that lights wet, in wind, on the first strike, always — your proudest possession  |
| 2   | A string of "treasures" the tall folk would call rubbish: a bent spoon, a doll's eye, a perfect pebble, a tooth |
| 3   | A trap, in miniature, that actually works, which you set off to demonstrate at the worst social moments         |
| 4   | A scorch-scar with a story you tell three different ways depending on the audience                              |
| 5   | A tally of every time you should have died, scratched somewhere on your person, that you are quietly proud of   |
| 6   | A whistle pitched so high only your kind and the ship's dogs flinch at it                                       |
| 7   | A song — yours, improvised, endless — about everyone aboard, updated after every fight                          |
| 8   | A small mean creature even uglier than you, that you love ferociously (name it)                                 |
| 9   | A wanted poster offering coin for you "dead or in a sack," that you have signed                                 |
| 10  | A length of fuse-cord coiled where a sensible person would not keep fuse-cord                                   |
| 11  |                                                                                                                 |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                     |
|-----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|     | A draconic scale, a dragon's cast-off tooth, or a relic of the big thing your warren worshipped             |
| 12  | A set of picks and pry-bars worn from a lifetime of getting into and out of places                          |
| 13  | A jar of something that should not be in a jar, that you are keeping for "an emergency"                     |
| 14  | The charred remains of the one thing you ran back into the fire to save                                     |
| 15  | A map of a town's sewers, drains, and gaps, drawn from the inside, that has saved your life twice           |
| 16  | A "lucky" object that has been on fire, underwater, and through a cannon's near-miss, and survived like you |
| 17  | A debt of loyalty to one taller person who, once, did not try to kill you — and you have never forgotten it |
| 18  | A pouch of caltrops, fish-hooks, and broken glass, for making any floor regret following you across it      |
| 19  | A trophy from the thing that was supposed to eat you, taken from the wrong end of it                        |
| 20  | A secret way off this ship that you have not told anyone about, just in case                                |

## BIG FOLK

*A kindred, not one people: half-orcs, minotaurs, hobgoblins, and the other large, strong, martial folk the Inner Sea greets with a drawn weapon — and a job offer.*

You are one of the big peoples, built on a scale the polite world finds threatening and the working world finds invaluable. Maybe you are a **half-orc**, born from a violence or a love the cities cannot bear to look at, too orc for the humans and too human for the orcs, welcome nowhere a roof keeps off the rain. Maybe you are a **minotaur**, raised among the old labyrinth-ruins, carrying a strength and a shame and a sense of direction that never fails even when everything else does. Maybe you are a **hobgoblin**, bred for a war-society of iron discipline and brutal order, who looked at the rank ahead of you and the chain around your neck and decided to desert the whole arrangement. What you share is that the Inner Sea taught you your body was a problem to be managed — and then you found a deck, where the only questions are *can you haul, can you fight, will you hold the line*, and for the first time the answer being yes made you an asset instead of an omen.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ You were muscle for someone — a Chelish workhouse, a hobgoblin legion, a gang on the docks of a colonial port — until you decided your strength would only ever work for *you* again. Who did you break with to get free, and are they still looking?
- ◆ You carry a discipline or a code from where you came up — a soldier's order, a labyrinth-keeper's patience, a half-orc's hard-won restraint — that the chaos of piracy tests every single day. What is it, and what happens on the day it finally breaks?
- ◆ You are trying to prove something — that you are more than the fist people reach for, more than the monster the stories promised. What's the thing you're chasing, and what will it take before you believe you've done it?

## NAMES

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Big Folk names run hard and plain, or defiantly proud: half-orcs take a forgettable human name to pass or a reclaimed deed-name to stop passing; minotaurs carry a birth-name and a place-name from the maze that raised them; hobgoblins are named by rank and unit until they shed it for one of their own. Examples across the kindred: *Grust*, *Oggun Pier-Breaker*, *Mara*, *Korthax of the Sunken Maze*, *Vell*, *Iron-Twelve* "Twelve."

A Big Folk raised among humans often carries a deliberately unremarkable name; one raised among a crew often wears the name the crew gave them, like a flag. A deserter hobgoblin's first free act is usually choosing a name that is not a number.

## TRINKETS

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*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                                     |
|-----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | A filed-down tusk, sawn horn-tip, or cut rank-braid — a piece of yourself you removed to pass, and kept because you stopped |
| 2   | A workhouse token, slave-tally, or legion service-disc, the number still legible, that you've never been able to throw away |
| 3   | A belaying pin worn smooth as a handle, that has settled more arguments than the captain                                    |
| 4   | A child's toy you carved for someone, never delivered                                                                       |
| 5   | A list of everyone who ever called you a thing instead of a name, kept for no reason you'll admit                           |
| 6   | A surprisingly delicate piece of scrimshaw or knotwork, your own work, that no one believes you made                        |
| 7   | A field-manual, drill-book, or labyrinth-map you were trained on, annotated in the margins by a younger, truer believer     |
| 8   | A big ugly animal that chose you and will not be un-chosen (name it)                                                        |
| 9   | A medal or commendation from a force that then refused to let you truly belong                                              |
| 10  | A folded square of cloth — a flag, a banner, a blanket — from the first crew or unit that took you in                       |
| 11  | A wanted notice that describes you only as "a large half-orc / a minotaur / a hobgoblin," which you find insulting          |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                                |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 12  | A pair of brass knuckles or a knuckle-bone, cast or carved from a chain you used to wear                               |
| 13  | A letter from a parent or a sworn-sibling, read so often the fold has worn through the page                            |
| 14  | A tooth, a tine, or a tag that isn't yours, taken from someone who learned not to test you twice                       |
| 15  | A drinking horn that holds exactly as much as you can carry and still climb the rigging                                |
| 16  | A small shrine to Cayden Cailean, the Accidental God, who took no one's pedigree into account                          |
| 17  | A length of anchor-chain you can still lift one-handed, that you keep to be sure you still can                         |
| 18  | A debt freely owed to you by a person who, for once, was glad to be in your debt                                       |
| 19  | A ball of red thread or a knotted cord — the trick that gets you out of any maze, or any port, the same way every time |
| 20  | A name carved into a beam below decks — yours — because you wanted there to be proof you were here                     |

## THE MADE

*A kindred, not one people: androids, automatons, homunculi, and the other thinking things that were built rather than born — and woke up anyway.*

You were not born. You were *made* — assembled, cast, grown in a vat, wound up, or breathed into being by someone who wanted a tool and got a person instead. Maybe you are an **android**, a synthetic body of ageless flesh and buried machinery, carrying a soul that has worn other bodies before this one and will move on after, hunting in this single lifetime for what it means to be a *self* and not a thing. Maybe you are an **automaton**, a frame of brass and old enchantment, a soldier or a servant whose makers are long dust, still walking because no one ever told you that you could stop. Maybe you are a **homunculus**, a small made-thing built to serve a master who is dead, or worse, *not* dead, and still believes they own you. The Inner Sea cannot decide whether you are property, miracle, or abomination, and reaches for a different one of the three depending on who can profit. The Shackles, which is built entirely of people who refused to be owned, is the one place that looks at a made thing claiming itself a free person and simply says: *prove it on the next watch*.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ You had a maker or an owner — a Chelish artificer, a Numerian salvage-crew, a wizard whose tower you walked out of. Are they dead, hunting you, or worst of all still legally entitled to you under Inner Sea law, and how close have they come to collecting?
- ◆ You are trying to become — or to prove you already are — a real person, with all the mess that entails. What specifically are you chasing (a feeling, a choice, a death you can call your own), and what have you done that frightened *you* by how alive it was?
- ◆ The crew took a while to decide you weren't a clever machine playing at a soul. Who vouched for you first, what did you do to earn it, and what do you owe them now?



## NAMES

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The Made are named in three ways: a maker's designation, dry and functional (*Unit Seven, Cataloguer, Vessel-9*); a name a Made chooses on waking, often abstract or aspirational (*Vigil, Ash, Nine, Tuesday, Hope*); or a name a crew gives them, affectionate and plain (*Tin, Brass, Doc*). Examples: *Vigil, Unit Seven (now just "Seven"), Ash, Brass, Cataloguer, Tuesday*.

Many of the Made keep their maker's designation the way a freed person keeps an old scar — not from love, but to remember. Choosing a *new* name is, for most, the first act that was truly their own.

## TRINKETS

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*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                                  |
|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Your maker's mark, stamped or etched somewhere on your frame, that you have tried and failed to file off                 |
| 2   | A single component you replaced yourself, badly, the first time you chose to keep living                                 |
| 3   | A logbook in your own hand, beginning the day you woke, that you are using to find out who you are                       |
| 4   | A bill of sale, a commission, or a deactivation order with your designation on it                                        |
| 5   | The tools and oil that keep you running, which you guard more carefully than any weapon                                  |
| 6   | A small repeating fault — a tic, a hum, a flicker — that you have stopped trying to fix because it feels like <i>you</i> |
| 7   | A list of human things you are teaching yourself to do convincingly: blinking, flinching, lying, grieving                |
| 8   | A wind-up bird, a lesser made-thing, that you tend like a child of your own (name it)                                    |
| 9   | A keepsake from a previous life your soul half-remembers but your body never lived                                       |
| 10  | The last order your dead maker gave you, that you are deciding whether you still have to obey                            |
| 11  |                                                                                                                          |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                                  |
|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|     | A relic of Numeria or some other place of fallen sky-metal, that hums when you hold it                                   |
| 12  | A perfectly kept human object — a comb, a ring, a pipe — belonging to no one you ever met, that you find comforting      |
| 13  | A diagram of your own internals that you did not draw and do not fully understand                                        |
| 14  | A "wanted" notice listing you as <i>recovered property</i> , that you carry to remind yourself it's a lie                |
| 15  | A charm or icon a religious crewmate pressed on you, insisting you have a soul; you have not thrown it away              |
| 16  | A jar of the vat-fluid, sky-metal filings, or clockwork dust you woke from                                               |
| 17  | A debt owed to you by the first person who treated you as a person; you intend to never call it in                       |
| 18  | A small idol — perhaps to Brigh, goddess of invention, who might be the nearest thing you have to a maker who loves you  |
| 19  | A scrap of music, a joke, or a poem that made you feel something the first time, that you replay deliberately            |
| 20  | A self-destruct phrase, a kill-word, or a shutdown command your maker built into you, that someone out there still knows |

## BEAST-FOLK

*A kindred, not one people: tengu, catfolk, ratfolk, merfolk, naga, and every other folk who wear an animal's shape and an animal's instincts under a thinking mind.*

You are one of the beast-folk — a person the tall, smooth, hairless world calls an *it* before it calls you anything else, and you have a creature's patience for that particular insult. Maybe you are **tengu**, crow-folk who live in the cracks of other people's cities and collect words the way magpies collect bright things. Maybe you are **catfolk** of the Amurrun, curious and proud and built for the rigging, landing on your feet out of habits older than language. Maybe you are **ratfolk** of the Ysoki, a tinker and a hoarder and a survivor who can fit through a gap the size of your own skull and has done it more than once. Maybe you are **merfolk**, the sea's own, who can only walk ashore by a bargain and pays for every hour of it. Maybe you are **naga**, serpentine and uncanny and far older than you look, carrying a coil of ancient memory the human world finds frightening. What you share is the animal under the skin — the instinct that fires before thought, the senses that read a room or a reef before anyone speaks — and the knowledge that the sea, at least, treats every kind of creature with the same honest indifference.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ You worked a great port — **Port Peril, Quent**, somewhere busier and crueller — in the spaces the tall folk overlook: the rigging, the bilges, the rumour-rich dark of the wharves. What did your senses catch there that you weren't meant to, and who's still angry about it?
- ◆ Your body answers to the sea in a way the others' don't — gills, claws, a tail, a coil, an instinct for current and weather — and it is both your gift and your leash. What can you do that they can't, and what does it cost you that they'll never understand?

- ◆ You come from a beast-folk community with its own ways and its own long memory — a tengu wharf-clan, an Amurrun pride, an Ysoki warren, a drowned merfolk court, a naga's ancient solitude. What does it expect of you out here, and what do you owe it?

## NAMES

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Beast-folk names follow their peoples and their instincts: tengu collect *good words* and onomatopoeia (*Kaw, Rattle, Two-Penny*); catfolk take lithe, proud names, often a hunt-name earned (*Sefu, Quick-Paw, Nadira*); ratfolk run to practical, scurrying names and nicknames (*Tisk, Gnaw, Pellet*); merfolk and naga carry long, liquid, half-unpronounceable true-names and give the surface a short one (*Vael, Ssira, the one they call "Tide"*). Examples across the kindred: *Kaw, Sefu Nine-Lives, Tisk, Vael of the Drowned Court, Ssirahl "Tide," Hark*.

Most beast-folk keep a true-name in their own tongue and hand the surface world a *deck-name* — a sound, a trait, a word they liked. The true-name is for kin and for the sea; the deck-name is for everyone else, and may change with the voyage.

## TRINKETS

---

*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                              |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | A hoard of small things — a button, a coin, a tooth, a scale, a bead — sorted by no logic but your own               |
| 2   | A notebook (or a memory) of phrases in nine tongues, each labelled with where you'd use it and on whom               |
| 3   | A whisker, a feather, a shed scale, or a tuft of fur that is <i>not</i> one of yours — you won't say whose           |
| 4   | A set of lockpicks filed from bone, or claws you keep filed sharp for exactly that purpose                           |
| 5   | A bargain-token from the sea — coral, a smooth stone, a knotted weed — that lets you keep walking ashore, for now    |
| 6   | A password, scent-mark, or call-sign to a place in a port you can no longer safely enter                             |
| 7   | A ledger of debts owed <i>to</i> you in favours and secrets, which you consider better than coin                     |
| 8   | A smaller beast, not of your kind, that you have half-tamed and wholly spoiled (name it)                             |
| 9   | A coin or relic from a country that no longer exists, kept because the shape of it is beautiful                      |
| 10  | A map of a place's roofs, bilges, currents, or burrows — the hidden ways, not the streets — marked for a fast escape |
| 11  |                                                                                                                      |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                                                |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|     | A charm against drowning, or against drying out, given by an elder, that has either worked perfectly or never been tested              |
| 12  | A song, a scent, or a story you collected off a dying sailor that you have never shared                                                |
| 13  | A coil of memory too old to be yours — a naga's inheritance, a thing you know without learning                                         |
| 14  | A wanted notice for you that gets your species wrong, which offends you professionally                                                 |
| 15  | A jar of water from the exact stretch of sea or river you were born to, going slowly stale                                             |
| 16  | A trophy from a hunt — a tooth, a tine, a band — that means more to you than any of them will guess                                    |
| 17  | A scrap bearing a single word, sigil, or scent-trace in a script no one you've shown can read                                          |
| 18  | A small idol of Norgorber, god of secrets, who appreciates a creature that knows how to keep them                                      |
| 19  | A whistle-, scent-, or tail-signal language, taught by your people, that carries across a crowded deck as nothing the tall folk notice |
| 20  | A secret you are carrying for someone, sealed and unread, that you have been paid not to open                                          |

## PLANETOUCHED

*A kindred, not one people: tieflings, aasimars, ifrits, undines, oreads, sylphs, and everyone else born with a plane in their blood — marked, at birth, by a heritage they did not choose.*

Somewhere up your bloodline a door was left open — to the Hells, to the heavens, to the elemental deeps where fire and water and stone are alive — and it left its sign on you. Maybe you are a **tiefling**, fiend-blooded, born with horns or hooves or eyes like coals into a Cheliox that breeds the infernal into its noble lines and then despises what it makes. Maybe you are an **aasimar**, touched by something brighter, with a glow under the skin and a destiny everyone keeps trying to write for you. Maybe you are **elemental-blooded** — an ifrit who runs hot and angry, an undine whose skin is always faintly wet, an oread heavy and slow as the seabed, a sylph the wind seems to follow — kin to forces older than any god's quarrel. What you all share is that strangers read your *birth* off your face before you open your mouth, and decide they already know what you are. They are wrong, and proving it is the work of a life. The Shackles, which is full of people refusing to be the thing they were born into, is the one sea where your blood is just one more rumour about you, no truer than the rest.

## BACKGROUND QUESTIONS

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- ◆ You were born into a **Chelish** house that dabbles in the infernal, and your blood paid for someone else's bargain — a mark, a debt, an expectation. Whose deal are you carrying, and what did you do when you decided it was not yours to honour?
- ◆ Your heritage showed early, in a Shackles port that took it for an omen — good or ill — and treated you accordingly ever since. Where, what did they decide you were, and how have you used or fought that ever since?
- ◆ The plane in your blood is *calling* — a pull toward the Eye, the deep, a far fire, a voice that claims you as kin — and you are not sure whether to answer it or drown it. What calls you, and what have you already done to keep from going?



## NAMES

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Planetouched names run three ways: a name given *for* the mark (hellish epithets, luminous celestial names, element-words); a "virtue name" a family hangs on a tiefling child like an apology (*Mercy, Temperance, Owed*); or a plain name chosen in defiance of all of it. Examples across the kindred: *Ember, Mercy Vane, Tide-in-the-Blood, Cassiel, Stone, Just "Smoke."*

Many planetouched carry the name their blood earned them and a second they chose — and answer to whichever tells them more about the person using it.

## TRINKETS

---

*Roll twice on a d20 and keep both.*

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                                         |
|-----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | A filed-down horn, a chipped hoof-cap, or a covered patch of glowing skin — a piece of the mark you tried to hide, and kept     |
| 2   | A copy of the infernal contract your bloodline signed, in a hand that is not quite ink                                          |
| 3   | A holy symbol you were handed at birth and have never decided how to feel about                                                 |
| 4   | A vial of water that is always faintly warm, or an ember that never quite goes out, or a stone that's heavier than it should be |
| 5   | A child's drawing of a "normal" version of you, made by someone who loved you anyway                                            |
| 6   | A list of the names strangers have called you on sight, kept out of spite or study                                              |
| 7   | A coin that runs hot, cold, or wet depending on a mood you can't predict                                                        |
| 8   | A small creature drawn to your heritage — a salamander, a will-o'-wisp, a too-clever fish (name it)                             |
| 9   | A letter from a celestial-touched sibling who got the destiny while you got the suspicion                                       |
| 10  | A feather, a scale, or a pinch of ash from the thing in your bloodline, that will not burn, rot, or dry                         |
| 11  |                                                                                                                                 |

| D20 | TRINKET                                                                                                |
|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|     | A bargain-token a fiend, an angel, or an elemental left for you "to use when you're ready"             |
| 12  | A wanted notice that lists your heritage as one of your crimes                                         |
| 13  | A scrap of a language you have never been taught but understand when you're frightened                 |
| 14  | The veil, hood, or paint you wear when you need a port to forget what you are                          |
| 15  | A mirror that shows the mark even when you've hidden it, which you keep to stay honest                 |
| 16  | A relic of the Eye, the deep, or a far plane that hums in tune with your blood                         |
| 17  | A debt owed you by the one person who, on meeting you, didn't flinch                                   |
| 18  | A small idol — to Besmara, who doesn't care what's in your veins, only what's in your hold             |
| 19  | A keepsake of the parent who was <i>not</i> the planar one, and loved you the ordinary way             |
| 20  | A sealed prophecy about you that you have never opened, and are not sure you believe in enough to burn |

# MAKE YOUR PIRATE

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*Make your pirate.*

A character in the Shackles is built from three pieces and a handful of details. The pieces answer three different questions, and none of them answers the other two:

- ◆ **Class** — *what can you do?* The toolkit that has kept you alive. (Part Six.)
- ◆ **Calling** — *why do you sail?* The obsession that keeps you from a quiet life ashore. (Part Five.)
- ◆ **Ancestry** — *who are you, and where are you from?* Purely who you are in the fiction; it grants no mechanics. (Step 4, below.)

Work through the steps in order. By the end you will have a character, a place at a crew, and a reason the sea will one day come to collect. Pencil, not pen — some of this is decided together with the table.

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## STEP 1 — CONCEPT

One sentence. *A press-ganged Chelish navigator who found God in a storm and never went home. A dockside cardsharp building an empire of favours. A thing the jungle spat back out.* You do not need a backstory yet — the class, calling, and ancestry will hand you most of one. You need a hook you are excited to play.

## STEP 2 — CHOOSE A CLASS

Your class is your competence. Pick one of the ten (Part Six) and take everything in its **Core Traits**:

1. Its **core skill** and **core domain** — your starting skill and domain. (Everyone can attempt most things; a skill or domain adds a die and means you are genuinely good at it. See Part Three.)
2. Its **resource** — a single evocative item with a value and domain.
3. Its **equipment** — take the listed gear, and **pick one** from the choice the class offers.
4. Both of its **core abilities** — the powers that define the class. You have these from the start.

You do **not** take any minor, major, or zenith abilities yet — those are *advances*, earned in play (see Advancement, below). You begin lean and grow into the legend.

## STEP 3 — CHOOSE A CALLING

Your calling is your engine. Pick one of the seven personal callings (Part Five); if you are torn, the choosing guide settles it. Then:

1. Take its **core ability**.
2. **Answer its four questions**. Two of them name other player characters — do this at the table, out loud, so your stories are already tangled before play begins.
3. **Roll (or choose) on its d10 carry table** — the object you bring to mark this life. It is not equipment. It is evidence.

Everyone also holds the shared **Piracy** calling alongside their personal one; you will build its side of things with the whole crew in Step 7.

## STEP 4 — CHOOSE AN ANCESTRY

Your ancestry is who you are before the dice hit the table. **It grants no mechanics** — no bonuses, no abilities, no protection. The storm does not care whether you are a half-orc or a Chelish noble; what matters is the grudges, loyalties, and reasons you are standing on a deck at the edge of the world.

An ancestry is built from a short lore block, **three background questions**, a set of names, and a d20 **trinkets** table. To make a character: read your ancestry's lore, **answer one of its three background questions**, choose a **name**, and **roll twice on its trinkets table** (keep both).

The Shackles ancestries are in **Part Seven**, in two groups: **cultures** (Shackleborn, Bonuwat, Chelaxian — for humans, elves, and the like, who are defined by their upbringing rather than their species) and **kindreds** (Small Folk, Goblinkin, Big Folk, The Made, Beast-folk, Planetouched — peoples set apart by their very nature). Pick one; more are easily built with the Ancestry Design Guide. If none fits, describe where you are from and answer three questions freeform — it costs you nothing mechanically either way.

## STEP 5 — YOUR RESISTANCES

You have five **resistance tracks** (Part Four): **Blood, Tide, Reputation, Luck, Gold**. They all start **empty** — a fresh character carries no stress.

**Protection** reduces stress before it is marked. You start with **0 protection** in every track unless a class ability or your equipment's **Block** tag says otherwise; protection is earned through advances, not bought as armour. Note any protection your starting abilities grant.

## STEP 6 — BONDS

You may begin with **one or two bonds** — real relationships in the Shackles who carry your story when you are not in the room (a quartermaster who owes you, a tavern-keeper who keeps your seat, a rival who would be insulted if anyone else killed you). A bond is a strong relationship, not necessarily a kind one. You can hold **at most three**; leave room to make more in play. (Full bond rules in Part Eleven.)

## STEP 7 — THE CREW, THE SHIP & THE HOME PORT

Piracy is not a solo act. As a table, build the thing you all share:

1. **Answer the four crew questions** from the Piracy calling together — the ship and what she cost, your first prize and what went wrong, your home port, and the enemy who already knows your flag.
2. **Define the ship** — her **size** and **quality** (Part Ten: *Ships of the Shackles*). A sound working vessel starts at Hull protection 1; that is plenty to begin.
3. **Name a home port** — a friendly landmark you can return to, heal at, and be hunted in (Part Eleven).

## STEP 8 — FINISHING TOUCHES

Name, look, voice, the flag you sail under. Write your two starting **active beats** (one or two — chosen each session thereafter from your calling or the Piracy pool; see Part Five). Then fill in your **character sheet** and you are ready to sail.

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## ADVANCEMENT — HOW YOU GROW

You grow by **hitting beats**, not by killing things or banking experience.

- ◆ At the end of each session you choose **two active beats** from your personal calling or the shared Piracy calling (the pools combine). You can hold only two at a time, and cannot hit more than one in a single situation.
- ◆ When you hit a beat, take an **advance** from your class at the matching level:
- ◆ **Minor beat** → **minor advance**. Most of your growth: a new skill, a new domain, +2 protection, or a named minor ability. Three of each class's minor advances are *generic and repeatable* (pick a skill, pick a domain, or +1 protection).
- ◆ **Major beat** → **major advance**. A larger power. Each major ability has **three sub-options** you can take as later advances to deepen it.
- ◆ **Zenith beat** → **zenith advance**. An endgame power. Taking one signals your character's story is reaching its end — often a single, world-changing act, sometimes triggered by your death or retirement.
- ◆ **Gaining a skill or domain a second time grants a knack** (Part Three) — roll that narrow thing with mastery.

The shape of advancement *is* the shape of the story. Minor advances are the texture of the good years; majors are the turning points; the zeniths — and the calling's **Downfall** — are where it all comes due. In the Shackles, the good times are real, and so is what comes after.

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## QUICK REFERENCE — THE BUILD

1. **Concept** — one sentence.
2. **Class** — core skill, core domain, resource, equipment (pick one), both core abilities.



3. **Calling** — core ability, answer four questions, roll a carry item.
4. **Ancestry** — lore, answer one question, name, roll two trinkets. (*No mechanics.*)
5. **Resistances** — five tracks empty; protection 0 unless an ability grants it.
6. **Bonds** — one or two to start (max three).
7. **Crew & ship** — answer the Piracy crew questions; set ship size/quality and a home port.
8. **Finish** — name, look, two active beats, fill the sheet.

# QUICK REFERENCE

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## THE ROLL

Roll a pool of **D10s**, **keep the single highest**. One die always, plus:

- ◆ **+1 die** for a relevant **skill**
- ◆ **+1 die** for a relevant **domain**
- ◆ **+1 die (mastery)** if a **knack** applies — max **4 dice**

| HIGHEST DIE | RESULT                                                                                    |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 10          | <b>Critical success</b> — what you wanted, plus extra. Step up your outgoing stress dice. |
| 8–9         | <b>Success</b> — what you wanted. No stress.                                              |
| 6–7         | <b>Success at a cost</b> — you get it, but take stress or a complication.                 |
| 2–5         | <b>Failure</b> — take stress; it goes wrong.                                              |
| 1           | <b>Critical failure</b> — take <b>double</b> stress.                                      |

**Difficulty: Standard** (keep highest) · **Risky** (drop the highest die first) · **Dangerous** (drop the two highest). Good/excellent gear, a plan, position, or help can step it down.  
*Roll only when the outcome is uncertain **and** failure costs something.*

## STRESS & FALLOUT

On a 2–7, mark stress to a **track** (the GM picks the track from the **fiction**, not the skill). Dice by severity: **D4** minor · **D6** serious · **D8** dangerous · **D10** catastrophic.

**Protection** reduces the rolled value first.

Then roll a **D12** vs. your **total** stress across all tracks:

| D12 VS.<br>TOTAL    | OUTCOME                                                                     |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Higher</b>       | No fallout — it accumulates.                                                |
| ≤ total, D12 = 1–6  | <b>Minor fallout</b> — clear the marked track.                              |
| ≤ total, D12 = 7–12 | <b>Major fallout</b> — clear <b>all</b> tracks; something changes for good. |

## THE FIVE TRACKS

| TRACK             | IS                                 | CLEARs BY                          |
|-------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| <b>Blood</b>      | wounds, exhaustion, drowning, fire | rest, food, a surgeon              |
| <b>Tide</b>       | the supernatural getting in        | ritual, arc-length story (hardest) |
| <b>Reputation</b> | your name and standing             | public deeds, bonds, haunts        |
| <b>Luck</b>       | fated misfortune                   | <b>only when its fallout fires</b> |
| <b>Gold</b>       | your material position             | plunder, good trades               |

*Equipment can never remove Tide, Luck, or Reputation.*

## THE FOUR GATES

Recurring abilities use exactly one: **once per situation · per session · per journey · per campaign**. No rounds, no initiative — durations are scoped to the fiction.

## EQUIPMENT

Roll the dice on the gear; **no suitable gear = D4**. Ladder: **D4** improvised · **D6** civilian · **D8** professional · **D10** exotic · **D12** legendary. Quality (separate axis): **Standard** / **Good** / **Excellent** / **Renowned** (Renowned grants a knack). Weapons tagged **Brave** / **Hunt** / **Plunder**; journey gear **Navigate**; healing **Tend Blood/Gold/Hull**.

**Common tags:** **Brutal** (roll 2 stress dice, keep highest) · **Piercing** (ignores Blood protection) · **Ranged** · **Reload** · **Tiring** (dice drops on a fail) · **Block** (+1 Blood protection) · **Spread** (catches nearby targets) · **Wyrd** (max roll → mark Tide).

## SKILLS & DOMAINS

**Skills (11):** Brave · Carouse · Command · Deceive · Endure · Hunt · Navigate · Plunder · Reckon · Tend · Vanish.

**Domains (9):** Deepwater · Shallows · Port · Outlaw · Colonial · Arcane · Faith · Ruins · Wilderness.

*A skill is what you can do; a domain is where you know it. Gain either a second time → a knack (roll that narrow thing with mastery).*

## BEATS & ADVANCEMENT

End of session: choose **two active beats** from your **calling** or the shared **Piracy** pool (hold two; one hit per situation). Hit a beat → take a class **advance** at its tier: **minor** (good years) · **major** (turning points) · **zenith** (the ending). The calling's **Downfall** is where the bill comes due.

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Contents · *Full rules: Part Two — The System, Part Four — Stress Tracks*

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*Resistance in the Shackles — player primer · compiled from the System Reference  
· the full rules and the GM's half live there.*